



Organizational culture and context in progressive prosecutorial reform: Lessons from Philadelphia

E. Rely Vîlcică^{*}, Megan E. Mohler, Jesse Brey, Jeffrey T. Ward

Temple University, Department of Criminal Justice, United States

ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Progressive prosecution
Criminal justice reform
Policy implementation
Organizational change

ABSTRACT

Across the country, many District Attorneys have been elected based on progressive platforms. While guidelines exist that center four core pillars around organizational context as essential to reform success—communication, education and training, leadership and staffing, and transparency and accountability—there is limited empirical research documenting organizational processes when implementing reform. This research explores the organizational context of policy implementation in the Philadelphia District Attorney's Office (DAO), as rolled out under a prominent figure of the progressive prosecution movement. The study draws on in-depth, semi-structured interviews ($n = 63$) with DAO employees conducted during 2021–2022 and relies on rigorous qualitative data analysis, including both deductive and inductive coding. Findings document staff perceptions in the four different domains under investigation. Specifically, the role of policy rollout and opportunities for input emerged as important sub-themes under communication while the nature of training and the role of reassignments were important sub-themes under training and education. Findings related to staffing and leadership underscored the role of firing, hiring and recruitment strategy, as well as organizational structure and leadership style. Lastly, several sub-themes emerged under transparency and accountability, pointing to the divergence between internal and external transparency efforts, inconsistency in metrics, and the important role of the office's research lab. The findings hold implications for understanding how progressive prosecutors can implement policies successfully and promote sustainable change.

1. Introduction

Over the last decade, the public has grown more aware of the role prosecutors play in perpetuating the cycle of mass incarceration in the United States (National Research Council, 2014; Pfaff, 2017) and have begun to elect a new type of chief prosecutor colloquially known as 'progressive chief prosecutors' (PCP) (Davis, 2019; Mitchell & Petersen, 2024). The rise of this type of prosecutor, and more broadly, of the Progressive Prosecution Movement (PPM) is documented well in the recent review by Mitchell and Petersen (2024), which attributes this phenomenon "to a disjuncture between the criminal justice policy preferences of state-level policymakers and voters" (p.1)—as law makers at the state levels have been reluctant to enact reforms that voters at the

local, especially large urban, level would prefer. Progressive prosecutors are thus seen as change agents who can bridge this gap by using their wide powers and authority to implement local reform without having to alter state laws (Mitchell & Petersen, 2024, p. 1, 7–8).

There is no definitive answer or consensus on what makes a prosecutor "progressive"—and critically, what would distinguish them from "traditional" prosecutors.¹ However, based on self-proclamation by elected prosecutors and other burgeoning policy literature and research attempting to measure such ideological distinctions (Bazelon, 2019; Davis, 2019; Fair and Just Prosecution (FJP), 2018; Hogan, 2022; Kaplan, Naddeo, & Scott, 2022; Levin, 2021; Mitchell & Petersen, 2024; Petersen, Mitchell, & Yan, 2024), progressive prosecutors lean heavily on aspirations to reduce mass incarceration and increase procedural

^{*} Corresponding author at: Department of Criminal Justice, College of Liberal Arts, Temple University; Gladfelter Hall, 5th Floor, 556; Philadelphia, PA 19122, United States.

E-mail address: rvilcica@temple.edu (E.R. Vîlcică).

¹ The use of the "progressive" label itself has been criticized as potentially inaccurate due to political connotations that may be misleading. Krinsky et al. (2023), for example, prefer the term "reform-minded prosecutors", pointing out how some Democratic DAs may self-proclaim to be progressive without actually enacting meaningful reform, while some Republican DAs may avoid such descriptors even though they are committed to reform (p. 1375). These are valid points. In line with the PPM literature and related scholarly discussions, in this paper we use the terms "progressive" and "reform-minded" interchangeably.

fairness. Prior research has identified some common policies and goals found in progressive prosecutorial offices that include: charge declinations and diversion; reducing or eliminating cash bail and otherwise avoiding unnecessary pretrial detention; reducing racial disparities; expanding access to alternative interventions for people who need treatment; working closely with community stakeholders; decriminalizing youth; increasing the integrity of the legal system; and reliance on data-driven approaches to policy (Balboni & Grometstein, 2020; Meldrum, Stemen, & Kutateladze, 2021; Mitchell & Petersen, 2024).

Despite prosecutors' immense power within the criminal legal system, progressive prosecutors have faced many challenges implementing desired policies (Davis, 2019; Mitchell & Petersen, 2024). While research on these challenges is sparse, numerous media reports have documented the opposition to progressive prosecutors from within and outside their offices. These challenges include: internal resistance by Assistant District Attorneys and supervisors attempting to stymie policy implementation (Dahm, 2019); resistance from other criminal justice stakeholders such as police officers and police unions (Davis, 2022; Kohler, 2023; Rex, 2018; Trinacria, 2018); and state legislatures, Attorneys General, and even Governors using their authority to limit the power of local progressive prosecutors (Cordeiro, 2017; Davis, 2022; Herndon, 2018; Kohler, 2023; Lacy & Grim, 2019; Mitchell & Petersen, 2024). These types of challenges could make progressive policy implementation difficult and, in fact, in some jurisdictions they have even led to recall elections (e.g., in San Francisco, see Bidar, 2022) and impeachment proceedings (e.g., in Philadelphia, see Rushing, Palmer, & Orso, 2022). In fact, Mitchell and Petersen (2024), documenting multiple instances of attempts to limit the powers of elected PCPs, identify the political backlash against PCPs as a "novel" type of challenge aimed at reform-minded prosecutors, and Goldstein even coined a new term, "toplash," for attacks of PCPs from institutions "above" them (Goldstein, 2024) and classifies such attacks in three categories: attempts to remove PCPs from their offices; attempts to narrow or limit the geographic or substantive jurisdictional authority of PCPs; and attempts to limit their discretion.

With these and other issues in mind, a sizeable normative and policy literature led by legal scholars and advocacy groups has made suggestions meant to guide progressive prosecutors toward more successful policy implementation. Chief among these are works by Bazelon (2020), Davis (2019), Fair and Just Prosecution (FJP, 2018), and Sklansky (2017) which separately laid out a set of recommendations for chief prosecutors to follow during implementation of their reform efforts. Broadly, these can be broken down into policy/goal-oriented suggestions and process-orientated recommendations. For example, FJP organizes its set of recommendations into two main pillars: 1) reducing incarceration and 2) increasing fairness. "Make diversion the rule" sits at the top of pillar one, while "Change the office culture and practice" tops pillar two.

Using these recommendations as a guide, the current research explores the context relevant to successful policy implementation in the Philadelphia District Attorney's office (DAO), as rolled out under the leadership of DA Larry Krasner, a prominent figure of the progressive prosecution movement nationwide (Austen, 2018; Passon, Brook, & Salazar, 2021). This study adds critical knowledge to the growing body of literature on prosecutorial reform by exploring facilitators and potential barriers to policy implementation and the organizational context surrounding said implementation. While some outcome evaluations and other empirical analyses of crime measures and changes in crime trends related to this new wave of prosecutor-led reforms have started to emerge (Agan, Doleac, & Harvey, 2021; Davis, Reich, Rempel, & Labriola, 2021; Foglesong et al., 2022; Goldrosen, 2022; Johnson, Davis, Labriola, Rempel, & Reich, 2020; Mitchell, Mora, Sticco, & Bogges, 2022; Owusu, 2022; Petersen et al., 2024; Taqi-Eddin, 2024; Wu & McDowall, 2024; Zhou et al., 2021), including in Philadelphia (Amaral et al., 2024; Hogan, 2022; Kaplan et al., 2022; Matei, Robin, Freeman, & Courtney, 2022; Ouss & Stevenson, 2023), there is a paucity of research

focused on implementation and organizational-related factors (Grodensky, Crozier, Gifford, & Garrett, 2023; Lowrey-Kinberg, Gould, & Bowman, 2022; Meldrum et al., 2021; Richardson & Kutateladze, 2021; Ward, Vîlcică, Brey, Mohler, & Dolbear, 2025). In fact, the recent review summarizing the empirical research on progressive prosecution identifies the need for qualitative and mixed-methods investigations into the essential role of the "contextual nature of criminal legal system operations and reform" as most critical for our understanding of why some current prosecutor-led reforms may succeed more than others, and for understanding the nature of cultural and institutional challenges that may potentially limit policy implementation and efficacy (Mitchell & Petersen, 2024; p. 19). Responding to this call, the research we present here captures precisely this via qualitative data, specifically in-depth interviews with internal stakeholders ($n = 63$) including DAO staff across various organizational levels (Executives, Assistant District Attorneys, paralegals, etc.) and documents, empirically, the organizational context and processes of major progressive prosecutor-led reform. Thus, our focus here is to center the perceptions of attorneys and staff working inside the DAO with knowledge of and experiences with organizational changes and implementation of progressive policies.

At the outset, it is important to situate this study within the larger socio-historical context of the research, which included a host of challenging issues for the administration of criminal justice from the ongoing COVID-19 global pandemic (e.g., see Miller & Blumstein, 2020), the "great resignation" (Formica & Sfodera, 2022), uptick in gun violence (e.g., Ssentongo, Fronterre, & Ssentongo, 2021; MacDonald, Mohler, & Brantingham, 2022), and larger nationwide challenges in recruiting and retaining criminal justice personnel (e.g., McLean, Cherry, & Alpert, 2023). Further, implementing criminal justice reforms is challenging generally (see Lattimore, 2022) and many prosecutor offices have historically shied away from providing the access necessary to uncover potential implementation challenges in the eyes of employees—even if the result of doing so leads to more promising criminal justice reform. In this way, this research between our independent research team and the Philadelphia DAO and its District Attorney's Transparency Analytics Lab (DATA Lab) breaks new ground. It seeks to speak to some of the most intractable barriers to achieving planned change, plaguing both the public and private sectors, that is, organizational inertia and difficulties with changing organizational culture, especially when organizations are situated within broader systems, such is the case with criminal justice agencies within the legal system. This work will come full circle and provide a brief account of how the research findings discussed herein have already sparked certain actions and positive changes by the Philadelphia DAO—which highlights the importance of strong researcher-practitioner partnerships in the study of prosecutorial reform. We begin by briefly reviewing the literature on the progressive prosecution movement, which was informative in the development of the study's data collection instrument, and other relevant research on prosecutorial-led reform and role of organizational context.

2. Literature review

2.1. Literature on the progressive prosecution movement

In their 2020 analysis of the progressive prosecution movement, Balboni and Grometstein (2020) identified 51 progressive District Attorneys elected in jurisdictions throughout the country between 2016 and 2020 (though the number has been fluctuating based on election cycles and counting methodology).² Accordingly, legal scholars and activists published works aimed at providing guidelines for reform success. While most recommendations focus on outcome-orientated policy, some others center on organizational change and culture. This

² Looking only at the 100 most populous counties, Mitchell and Petersen (2024), identified 41 progressive District Attorneys.

latter component of the prescriptive literature informs the present study's four guideline pillars: 1) Communication; 2) Education & Training; 3) Leadership & Staffing; and 4) Transparency & Accountability. We briefly summarize each below.

Under the Communication pillar, progressive prosecutors are urged to communicate early and often. Communication with external stakeholders (e.g., police, courts, community organizations) should take the form of open dialogue that allows for input and feedback, with the ultimate aim to obtain buy-in from other criminal justice actors (Davis, 2019). Communication within the office should be transparent and direct in order to enhance policy clarity (Sklansky, 2017) and to be representative of an office culture that promotes the values of justice and fairness (Sklansky, 2016), such as sharing success stories and data within the office (Davis, 2019).

Under the Education & Training pillar, chief prosecutors are urged to implement required trainings that cover a wide range of topics. These trainings should help convey to prosecutors why it is important to implement reforms (Davis, 2019). In addition, education and training should set up experiential opportunities for prosecutors to better understand the consequences of their decisions and the lived experiences of justice-involved individuals, such as meeting with formerly incarcerated individuals and visiting jails and prisons (FJP, 2018).

Under the third pillar of recommendations, Leadership & Staffing, progressive prosecutors should ensure that they have an office staffed with people who share their vision or are amenable to reform policies. This can take the shape of hiring new recruits that are reform-minded and providing education opportunities to more traditionally focused prosecutors who are already in the office (Davis, 2019). Those who are not amenable and willing to follow progressive policies should be fired (Davis, 2019). Importantly, supervisory roles would need to be filled by attorneys sharing the progressive vision as they have critical oversight over daily decision making (Davis, 2019). Additionally, when recruiting new hires, the office should focus on increasing diversity and reporting out on staff diversity (FJP, 2018).

The final pillar, Transparency & Accountability, addresses the tendency for district attorney's offices to work behind closed doors—for a long time considered the “black box” of the criminal legal system, with the least amount of visibility. Under this promise, prosecutorial offices are to collect and report outcome data to the public (FJP, 2018) as well as provide measurable proxies for fairness and other progressive values (Sklansky, 2018) (e.g., report on years of incarceration saved). For example, Philadelphia DAO, through its DATA Lab, has released several such reports, including on mass supervision (Philadelphia District Attorney's Office, 2021a), conviction integrity (Philadelphia District Attorney's Office, 2021b) and racial injustice (Philadelphia District Attorney's Office, 2023). Progressive metrics should also be adopted to evaluate employees performance (FJP, 2018), to replace the more traditional metrics, such as conviction rates. Lastly, data collection is often inter-agency dependent, thus prosecutorial offices are urged to collaborate with other agencies to gather and share data related to progressive outcomes (FJP, 2018).

2.2. Research on progressive reform metrics

There is also now a growing body of evaluation research that focuses both on developing metrics by which reform success can be measured (Concannon & Hemmady, 2020; Kutateladze et al., 2018; Moy, Martin, & Sklansky, 2018) as well as evaluations focused on specific policies or outcomes (Agan et al., 2021; Goldrosen, 2022; Hogan, 2022; Ouss & Stevenson, 2023; Taqi-Eddin, 2024). Some researchers have suggested using process-oriented (e.g., types of cases prosecuted) and purpose-oriented (e.g., public safety, fairness) approaches for performance metrics (Concannon & Hemmady, 2020). Others have suggested an adaptable generic scorecard index (Moy et al., 2018). The Prosecutorial Performance Indicators (Kutateladze, et al., n.d.) proposes 55 indicators in three areas: capacity and efficiency; community safety and

well-being; and fairness and justice.

Additionally, some research has begun to look at how progressive policies affect certain outcomes, including crime. One study by Agan et al. (2021) looked at 35 jurisdictions, employing Average Treatment Effect on the Treated (ATT) analyses, with the date of the progressive prosecutor assuming office serving as the beginning of the “treatment”. The study reported that the policies did not alter serious crime, including homicide, although there was some evidence that there was an increase in minor offenses. On the other hand, Hogan (2022), using synthetic control modeling for one jurisdiction, reported that the overall decrease in the prosecutions during the tenure of a progressive DA was associated with an increase in homicides—though the findings of this study are not without limitations (see Kaplan et al., 2022). More recently, research by Foglesong et al. (2022); Foglesong, Levi, Henry, Bouchot, and Wildeman (2024) concludes that recent crime trends in progressive jurisdictions have been driven by hyperlocal social, environmental, and economic conditions rather than progressive policies. Lastly, one outcome evaluation by Goldrosen (2022) focused on charge declination and reports that policy changes such as declining low-level marijuana charges by prosecutors did not affect police behavior: arrest rates for marijuana remained the same. This finding highlights how prosecutorial reform efforts may be stymied by external stakeholders.

In Philadelphia, Ouss and Stevenson (2023), found that a no-cash bail policy increased pretrial release (on own recognizance or signed bond) without sacrificing public safety or integrity of trial (no increases in pretrial rearrest and failures to appear). Looking at the impact of progressive policies on gun cases, Amaral et al. (2024) reported that the arrival of progressive prosecution in Philadelphia had a very small effect on gun case processing. Additionally, a MacArthur Foundation report addressing racial disparities found that Black defendants received lengthier probation and incarceration than their White counterparts (Matei et al., 2022). Similarly, an internal DAO report on racial injustice revealed racial disparities at multiple levels (charging, bail and pretrial arraignment, and sentencing) during 2015–2022, calling on all partners in the criminal legal system and social institutions at large to address structural issues that lead to racial disparities.

Outcome evaluation efforts are commendable and efforts focused on providing guidance on reform metrics provide a clear research agenda for social scientists interested in evaluating the success of the progressive prosecution movement and related reforms. However, knowing how long reform efforts can take to make lasting change, outcome assessments at this stage may be premature or incomplete, which may explain why some of the evidence summarized above may be conflicting. Furthermore, a good deal of the prescriptive literature focuses on the changes to the organizational processes and culture, yet the extant research on metrics and performance indicators for the most part neglects the organizational context of reform.

2.3. Implementation and organizational related research on progressive prosecutorial offices

We found two studies delving into organizational culture (Lowrey-Kinberg et al., 2022; Meldrum et al., 2021) and three delving into implementation matters (Grodensky et al., 2023; Richardson & Kutateladze, 2021; Ward et al., 2025), thus we will briefly review those as well.

Meldrum et al.'s (2021) study speaks generally to office culture. The study sought to identify whether there is a clear distinction in orientation between “progressive” versus “traditional” prosecutors. The study distributed a survey to 316 prosecutors across four jurisdictions, all considered to be progressive. The results confirmed the existence of the two distinct individual orientations and that these orientations related to different policy priorities: “progressive” prosecutors prioritized diversion and avoiding unnecessary pretrial detention while “traditional” prosecutors prioritized convictions. This research highlights how a lack of cohesive organizational culture, under which antagonistic individual orientations co-exist, can lead to divergent outcomes, some of

which may undermine achievement of the office reform goals.

Similarly, [Lowrey-Kinberg et al. \(2022\)](#) examined how prosecutors understand their role within the criminal justice system and how this role impacts their charging decisions. Based on interview and focus group data from three different jurisdictions, the study categorized prosecutors as adopting three distinct roles: Enforcers, Reformers, and Advocates. These roles, in turn, explained different charging approaches. Enforcers are described as seeing things as black and white, with narrow interpretations of the law, and making charging decisions accordingly. Reformers consider each case to be unique and use more discretion in their charging based on various case circumstances. Advocates feel a responsibility to get justice for victims and often dehumanize the defendant, leading to charging decisions that are the most punitive. The study reported that these role orientations were not evenly distributed within each office analyzed and that they interacted with and affected office culture. When both a prosecutor's assumed role and the general office culture paralleled one another, prosecutors appeared content with their role. A disconnect between the individual's role and office culture contributed to role conflict. More senior prosecutors would often approach this conflict by finding ways to circumvent official orders, such as a Reformer in an Enforcer-leaning office using a grand jury and convincing them not to indict, instead of outright dismissing the charges themselves. On the other end, both Enforcers and Advocates expressed frustration over role conflict in a Reformer-leaning office culture. They too reported circumvention mechanisms, such as forming stronger relationships with the police and coaching them on how to collect evidence to ensure convictions.³ Overall, the findings from this study highlight how individual orientation in conflict with office orientation could lead to barriers in a progressive prosecutorial agency.

In research that looked more directly at organizational culture and barriers to reforms, [Richardson and Kutateladze \(2021\)](#) conducted semi-structured interviews with 47 prosecutors in two Florida jurisdictions known to be reform minded. The authors point out that often system and organizational inertia can temper reform processes, as major policy changes may face resistance both internally and externally. Findings showed that reform-minded goals, like fairness and community engagement, were often touted as top priorities; yet the interviews revealed internal barriers to fully realizing these priorities. A chief issue related to the organizational culture was the pre-existing norms held by prosecutors embracing a traditional role orientation, inconsistent with progressive priorities. Additionally, the study reported that prosecutors typically embrace a case-focused decision-making process that often disregards the overall effects of their decision-making in the aggregate. These issues get confounded by breakdowns in internal communication that can lead to unclear messaging. In short, this study suggests that existing norms and inconsistent or ambiguous internal communication may get in the way of effective implementation.

[Grodensky et al. \(2023\)](#) conducted interviews with all 19 ADAs at a small office headed by a progressive DA, focusing on the prosecutors' experiences implementing five different progressive approaches in the plea bargaining process. While the interviews highlight some nuanced and complex situations in which implementation was not always straightforward, overall they revealed successful implementation. Taking a case-by-case approach, ADAs used their discretion to drop weak cases and low-level offenses, as well as offer recommendations for less punitive sentences, successfully balancing the issues of public safety and leniency. In this small office, buy-in to progressive ideals seemed rather unanimous and there was no official written policy at the time of the interviews. The study thus leaves open questions about whether such approaches to policy implementation and obtaining buy-in can be similarly successful in larger organizations.

³ While such actions are seen by these individuals as "circumventing" mechanisms, eventually, their actions/alterd behavior contribute to the broad progressive-oriented goal of achieving "conviction integrity".

[Ward et al. \(2025\)](#) administered an online survey to a sample of more than 100 attorneys and staff in the 600+ person Philadelphia DAO to measure several dimensions of implementation fidelity of progressive prosecution policies in a holistic manner. Of note, attorneys and staff were generally strongly supportive of progressive prosecution policies on the whole, and self-reported strong adherence to policy directives. At the same time, respondents reported that policies were not especially clear overall, with the greatest clarity issues related to the specifics of how the policies were to direct day-to-day decision making (e.g., presumptive actions and appropriate use of discretion). Participants also reported on potential barriers to successful policy implementation, identifying the largest barriers to be internal to the DAO (e.g., staff turnover, workload, resources), with external stakeholders across the criminal justice system (e.g., police, judges, probation/parole, and bail commissioners), and in exchanging information (e.g., within and outside of the agency). Overall, this study suggests a potential disconnect between an office's holding a progressive vision and its ability to implement it fully, at least in large prosecutorial offices—standing in contrast to the earlier study ([Grodensky et al., 2023](#)) and underscoring the need for more in-depth investigations into the organizational context of implementation and potential jurisdictional and organizational-size variation.

If we put all these studies in the context of the review of progressive prosecutorial offices and their policies by [Balboni and Grometstein \(2020\)](#), it is rare that even a single chief prosecutor can be said to fully subscribe to a progressive vision on the role of the prosecutor's office, let alone an entire DAO staff. Thus, [Balboni and Grometstein \(2020\)](#) place "progressive" chief prosecutors on a spectrum, ranging from "pruners" (i.e., individuals who pursue small-scale less controversial changes) to "disruptors" (i.e., chief prosecutors who attempt large-scale reform on a wide range of issues). Additionally, the review by [Mitchell and Petersen \(2024\)](#) highlights inconsistencies in how progressive offices are operationalized across studies, stemming from the lack of agreement on a definition of what it means to be a "progressive prosecutorial office". This echoes the sentiments expressed by [Krinsky, Murray, and Romero \(2023\)](#) in their preference for using the label "reform-minded" rather than "progressive". Arguably, placing DAs and DAO offices on a spectrum, as [Balboni and Grometstein \(2020\)](#) do, allows for a more accurate and nuanced way of describing the vision of a prosecutorial office rather than the simple dichotomy that the "progressive" versus "traditional" labeling would imply.

This being said, all these studies underscore the notion that organizational culture is extremely relevant in the implementation process of progressive prosecution policies. Our study seeks to add to this small body of literature by providing an in-depth qualitative analysis of the organizational context of the Philadelphia District Attorney's Office under the leadership of one of the most recognizable PPM figures. More specifically, we note facilitators to success and barriers that stand in the way of the prescriptive guidelines for implementing policy changes. As the PPM is still very much in its infancy, it is critical that social science documents implementation processes. Our research aims to better understand the ongoing process of implementing reforms and highlights issues around proposed guidelines for reform-minded prosecutors during the early years of the Progressive Prosecution Movement.

3. Methodology

3.1. Sampling & data collection

Sampling. The study sample consists of 63 employees of the Philadelphia District Attorney's Office. We aimed to interview 10 % of the entire 622 person DAO staff at the time of study. We used random sampling in conjunction with purposive sampling to obtain information from a wide range of employees while also inviting twenty-five specific individuals to participate whose views we deemed critical to capture given their role in creating and establishing policy guides and

Table 1
Sample descriptives.

	Sample	Population	χ^2 GOF
N	63	622	
Race/Ethnicity			4.80 ($p = 0.19$)
White	45 (71.4 %)	371 (59.6 %)	
Black	14 (22.2 %)	161 (25.9 %)	
Hispanic	2 (3.2 %)	34 (5.5 %)	
Other	2 (3.2 %)	56 (9.0 %)	
Sex			1.31 ($p = 0.25$)
Female	32 (50.8 %)	360 (57.9 %)	
Male	31 (49.2 %)	262 (42.1 %)	
Division			9.41 ($p = 0.40$)
Executive	6 (9.5 %)	27 (4.3 %)	
Administration and Technology	6 (9.5 %)	46 (7.4 %)	
Gun Trafficking and Community Engagement	2 (3.2 %)	25 (4.0 %)	
Investigations	6 (9.5 %)	44 (7.1 %)	
Juvenile	7 (11.1 %)	44 (7.1 %)	
Law	8 (12.7 %)	70 (11.3 %)	
Pre-Trial	8 (12.7 %)	102 (16.4 %)	
Trial	14 (22.2 %)	176 (28.3 %)	
Miscellaneous	5 (7.9 %)	57 (9.2 %)	
No Division Assigned	1 (1.6 %)	31 (5.0 %)	
Title			13.07 ($p < 0.01$)
Assistant District Attorney (ADA)	42 (66.7 %)	304 (49.0 %)	
Paralegal	3 (4.8 %)	142 (22.9 %)	
Other	18 (28.6 %)	175 (28.2 %)	

expectations (e.g., individuals in executive, policy, and director or mid-management positions) or as primary line staff tasked with carrying out DAO policies on a daily basis (e.g., Assistant District Attorneys). In all, we sent emails to 254 individuals inviting them to participate in the study. This occurred in three phases, with 85 individuals invited to participate during the first two phases, and 84 during the last phase. Each individual was sent an original invitation, followed by up to two additional reminders sent at two and four weeks after the initial invitation; reminders were sent only to non-responders. We stopped the sampling process when we achieved the intended 10 % of the whole target population, that is 63 individuals.⁴ By this time in the data collection, it was also evident to all core members of our research team that we achieved saturation.

Table 1 provides the sample characteristics, including demographics and roles in the organization. To respect the protections established in the IRB protocol, holding that we cannot provide identifiable information if the group/unit represented has fewer than 10 persons, we grouped executive and policy leadership in with the “Other” category. We include in Table 1 the population information along with chi-square goodness of fit tests assessing whether the observed sample percentages are significant different from those expected based on the population values. Of note, only in the case of the Title (position) variable is there statistical evidence that the sample significantly differs from the population. More specifically, ADAs are overrepresented, and paralegals are underrepresented in the sample—which is not surprising for reasons discussed above. The sample is roughly 71 % White, 22 % Black, and

about 3 % each Hispanic and Other. Sample participants are split evenly between female and male. The trial division (including both misdemeanor/Municipal Court unit and felony/Court of Common Pleas unit, as well as dedicated units to homicides, family violence/sexual offense cases, and victim services) is the modal division category, comprising about 22 % of all participants. Pre-trial (including charging, diversion, and pre-trial/bail units), law, and juvenile division categories comprise at least 10 % of the sample. Two-thirds of respondents are ADAs, and more than one-fourth are categorized as ‘other’, with paralegals making up less than 1 in 20 participants.⁵ We should also note that 44 (71 %) of the respondents reported having 4 years or less experience in Philadelphia DAO, and thus can be considered recruits by DA Krasner. The remaining 18 (29 %) were hired by previous DAs, with an average of 14.5 years of experience and a range of 5–37 years.

Data Collection. The main method of data collection consisted of semi-structured interviews. Semi-structured interviews are a guided conversations where specific questions are followed by reflexive probes and a widely used qualitative method effective for this type of research (Ahlin, 2019; Yin, 2009). We conducted the interviews during July 2021–March 2022. As the study unfolded during the COVID-19 pandemic, all interviews were conducted via Zoom, and on average lasted about an hour. To ensure trust and confidentiality and candid responses, the interviews were not audio or video recorded. Instead, we relied on a dual-interviewer extensive notetaking process: the primary interviewer asked the questions/led the discussion and took notes, and a secondary interviewer captured the conversation as it occurred (typing). Once each interview was completed, the primary interviewer reviewed

⁴ We originally planned for two phases of data collection in hopes of collecting ~60 interviews from our initial invitations to 169 individuals. After completing 45 interviews during the first two phases, our core research team members felt we were at (or nearing) saturation. At this time, we elected to complete a third phase of data collection to reach our intended 10 % sample target. Our third and final phase used randomized sampling applying sampling weights based on division, units, and titles in an effort to capture any viewpoints that were potentially unrepresented in our data collection from the first two phases.

⁵ There are three paralegals in the sample and, although they are not necessarily featured prominently in our analysis they are retained for completeness; in their roles, they offer another vantage point on organizational culture within the agency.

Table 2
Overview of communication.

Subtheme	ID / Role	Representative Comments
Learning of Policy Rollouts	29 ADA	<i>It does seem like they are communicating to others in the CJS, since I will hear about policies from them (others outside the office, e.g., a judge) before the office. With the gun violence they changed it to only be prosecuted in one room with one judge. We didn't hear about it until weeks after it had already been put into effect. And then got reprimanded for not doing it correctly.</i>
	Misc.	
	206 ADA Juvenile	
Opportunities for Input	80 Other Pre-trial	<i>It's not possible to end cash bail, the way we have brought about this policy has not been communicated well to the office or the community, so it has brought a lot of backlash from judges and the community.</i>
	193 ADA Trial	
	52 ADA Law	
Unit-level vis-��vis Office Wide Communication	135 Other Executive	<i>My immediate supervisors and even a few notches above tend to do very well with sending you an email. Sometimes they will call you to let you know there has been a change.</i>
	144 ADA Trial	
	26 ADA Juvenile	
Role of the DATA Lab	144 ADA Trial	<i>Communicating early and often doesn't really happen internally. There is not really a day-to-day discussion about these issues, people just get bogged down in their daily activities.</i>
	26 ADA Juvenile	
	144 ADA Trial	

the notes of the secondary interviewer and tracked changes, after which the secondary interviewer reviewed/approved all changes.⁶

3.2. Analysis & coding process

Interview notes were collated and data were input into Atlas.ti (version 9.1.2) qualitative data analysis software. Atlas.ti tools allow for efficient organization and retrieval of coded data and development of in-depth insights (Frieze, 2019). We relied on a hybrid coding approach combining deductive and inductive coding (Saldana, 2016). The deductive codes (main themes) were established a-priori based on the semi-structured instrument and informed by prior literature – see discussion below and Appendix for the interview protocol. Inductive codes were used to interpret and categorize the data based on sub-themes emerging from the respondents' answers and the ensuing reflective probes asked by the interviewers.

Given the large number of interviews, in order to ensure consistency in data analysis across all of them, the first step in the analysis process was to create a codebook, which was done via an iterative process. Specifically, 10 % of cases were independently coded by three team members. As part of this process, segments of interviews/data were read and assigned codes that emerged from the content, which were grouped into sub-themes as patterns and connections became apparent. This was followed by team meetings to reconcile any potential differences and further refine the codebook and capture nuances of the data more accurately. The refinement process entails merging of similar codes into more general categories, splitting some codes into more specific ones, linking related codes, or adding new codes or renaming codes as new

insights emerge, to better reflect the evolving interpretation of the data. This iterative refinement process ensures that the evolving coding structure accurately represents the underlying themes and sub-themes in the data (Frieze, 2019). Once the codebook was finalized, each (remaining) interview was coded by a single member of the research team.

It is important to briefly discuss items in the semi-structured protocol relevant to this paper. As stated earlier, the overarching aim of this research was to identify facilitators and barriers to contemporary prosecutor-led criminal justice reform in Philadelphia. For the purposes of this research, "reform" was used globally, to encompass the multitude of progressive policy initiatives undertaken under the leadership of the Krasner administration. Thus, we asked about general policy priorities as well as specific policies (e.g., bail). Additionally, we asked about both internal and external factors that may affect policy implementation/success, including, for example, relationships with other partners/external stakeholders. Of course, most relevant for the current paper focused on organizational-related processes are the protocol items that we created centered around recommendations on the concepts/pillars discussed in the section above: communication; education & training; leadership & hiring; and transparency & accountability. Additionally, because the data collection happened during the COVID-19 pandemic restrictions, our protocol also attempted to understand how these restrictions and other unanticipated challenges might have affected implementation of above pillars. In essence, the PPM organizational-related concepts and the unanticipated/COVID-19 related findings encompass the results of the "main themes" below (based on deductive coding), while the sub-themes were identified mostly via inductive coding.

As a final point, we also wanted to ensure that our analysis considered the interpretation of the results by main stakeholders, that is, DAO leadership. To this end, in addition to regular meetings our research team had with the office's research team during the research project, we also presented the findings of the study to the DAO executive team (in

⁶ At the onset of the study, we relied on a team of 10 interviewers; however, the vast majority of the interviews were conducted by the authors of the current paper (the two investigators acting as primary interviewers and two research assistants/doctoral students acting as secondary interviewers).

two two-hour Research-to-Action meetings) and interviewed DA Krasner, in a two-hour interview (all in-person). Together, this provided ample opportunity for the research team to gain a nuanced understanding of intended policy and goals as well as to capture the formal perspective of the leadership team on the context of policy implementation. In this regard, our study also addresses a major limitation in the socio-legal literature that focuses on the gap between “law/policy on the books, i.e., as proposed” vs. “law/policy in action” (Bourdieu, 1987; Pound, 1910) which often neglects to include the views of the policy creators (Black, 1972; Gould & Barclay, 2012). Although the impressions emerging from these meetings are not part of the study’s main data, our discussion of the study’s main themes and sub-themes references such impressions when relevant for providing further context to the interpretation of the findings. Importantly, these meetings allowed for development of several courses of action or planned changes by DAO, in response to the study’s findings, which will be highlighted in our discussion section.

4. Findings

We begin with a presentation of findings related to the communication guideline pillar, followed in order by education and training, leadership and staffing, and transparency and accountability. At the end of each of these four major themes, we provide an overview summary of the findings, broken down by subtheme, with further illustrative quotes (see Tables 2 through 5).⁷

4.1. Communication

Virtually all respondents shared impressions about both internal communication (e.g., between office leadership and line staff) and external communication with other criminal justice agencies or partners. Several sub-themes emerged, which include: learning of policy roll-outs; opportunities for input; unit-level vis-à-vis office-wide communication; and role of the office’s research lab (District Attorney Transparency and Analytics Lab [aka DATA Lab]).

4.1.1. Learning of policy rollouts

Staff offered numerous comments regarding communication of new policies, both on the initial roll out of policies and follow-up communication about them. While some respondents felt they were made aware of policies via internal channels, others felt they would be caught off guard when new policies came out and reported hearing about them in court from judges and defense counsel, or through various forms of media such as, *Philadelphia Inquirer*, press conferences or social media platforms. For example, Participant 14, an ADA in the trial division, said: *...they often use press conferences and press releases pretty quickly when they have made policy changes, sometimes before we even know about it in the office.* Other staff members felt only individuals affected by certain policies regularly would have in-depth knowledge about them. The confusion, frustration, and sometimes embarrassment, of hearing about new policies from outside sources was evident in multiple interviews. Take, for example, this comment, from Participant 61 (ADA):

A lot of my criticisms stem from the lack of clarity on the policy goals and a lot of this stuff isn’t actually put in writing. I will be in court and will hear from a judge about a policy and tell him that’s news to me.

A great deal of comments regarding communication with external stakeholders revolved around policy development and rollout. Perceptions were mixed, with some indicating positive opinions while others less so. For example, Participant 77 (Other, Juvenile), told us: *I think we communicate well. Almost immediately when we try to implement a policy,*

we speak to every agency involved, and DAK has very good community outreach. As this quote demonstrates, this participant has a very positive view on the leadership’s efforts to engage with external stakeholders. By contrast, Participant 27 (Other, Juvenile) expressed qualms:

I think the disservice they’ve done to themselves is in communication... Be more open about what informs your decision and I think that’s an opportunity that is really missed... There is a whole group of people that want to be on your side and you’re not meeting them where they are at. They are all or nothing. You’re with us or against us. That isn’t how policy or politics works. I wish there was a sense of trying to get more people on board. Everyone that isn’t you, isn’t necessarily bad (Participant 27, Other, Juvenile).

Asked to provide context as to why some policies are announced to the staff at the same time as they are announced to the public/other stakeholders, the leadership team explained that it has concerns about potential leaks of policies by some staff members before the office would be ready to announce them publicly. They underscored that they strive to balance the need to share the policies in advance with the risk of policies being undermined both internally and/or externally.

4.1.2. Opportunities for input

Participants also expressed frustration related to follow-up communication about policies. Some respondents felt that policies would be discussed in an abstract sense and that the staff were not given opportunities to discuss issues with practical implications. They stated that this in turn negatively impacted the effectiveness of the policies since they were the people on the ground implementing them. For example, we heard from Participant 206 quoted in the table discussing the goals of the office who then went on to say:

...And we are the ones in courtroom and know if the approaches would work so then we could provide feedback on whether this is realistic or even possible to help shape it and say this is how we can reach that goal. So, it is kind of like talking about what [it] actually means to be a progressive prosecutor in the court room. (Participant 206, ADA, Juvenile).

Some people also took the opportunity to discuss how inadequate communication has implications not only for policy clarity and implementation but also for gaining external support. See, for example, the quote in Table 2 from Participant 80 (Other, Pre-trial) discussing how poor communication on the development and roll-out of the bail policy led to backlash from judges and the community. In addition, other participants were more specifically concerned with feeling heard. Some people felt that input was not sought out, or when it was, was not taken seriously—see, for example, the quote from Participant 193 in Table 2. Additionally, some participants discussed with us a period when outside consultants were brought in to help gather staff feedback, compile a report, and have a retreat where policy team and leadership could discuss the findings. One of the goals of this retreat, as relayed to us, was to help improve policy implementation and therefore effectiveness—and the inclusion of line staff feedback at the time was seen as a meaningful effort by the leadership to engage with them. However, our respondents reported that this effort did not result in meaningful change which only served to increase staff frustration.

Lastly, the lack of dialogue between leadership and line staff could possibly have other unintended consequences as well. Some participants shared that they felt the lack of dialogue, or willingness to hear line staff frustrations, also contributed to staff turnover (a sub-theme on its own, discussed below). For example, one participant told us:

Over the years the unwillingness to listen to people around the office about what would make things better and unwillingness to listen to people about how to do things has led to people leaving in droves and vast unhappiness and have made conditions worse... (Participant 184, ADA, Pre-trial).

⁷ Participants quotes are identified by a unique ID number and by their title and division.

4.1.3. Unit-level vis-à-vis office-wide communication

During our conversations, some staff believed that the size of the organization, and the varied, siloed nature of each unit impacted communication, with some participants reporting that within-unit communication may be strong, but more generally, office-wide communication was more lacking. Some participants suggested that it may be up to individual supervisors to maintain strong communication and continuously follow-up on policy goals/implementation (see quote from Participant 52 in Table 2).

Others acknowledged the simple reality of working in a large government office that employs hundreds of people in various roles and responsibilities and housed in different locations:

Well this is a huge office...but we are 300 or so lawyers, 300 support staff spread across 8 floors in one building, and other buildings. We don't do well keeping in touch with the supervisors and expressing how they should spread the goals to those they supervise. (Participant 77, Other, Executive).

Thus, this individual believes communication around specific policies can be enabled or hampered by individual supervisors and how well they communicate to those they supervise. This belief could be especially true for people in certain units, specifically trial units, who are in court daily working through high caseloads. These attorneys and support staff may simply not have the time or energy to keep up with internal office communication, press updates or be able to get face-to-face time with other staff. Some people discussed the nature of this challenge specifically for ADAs in courts:

It is hard to maintain that broader idea of reform when you are smacked with 30–40 cases a day and seeing victims. It is easy to become a little jaded. And you aren't hearing from the top brass very often. You hear from them in the beginning during training, but after that you are not hearing from them. It's not that they don't do anything, they will have classes every now and then but the people that need it the most can't do it because they are too busy, they are in court or dealing with cases. They [leadership] try to reiterate the bigger picture, but it's hard. (Participant 242, ADA, Law).

We asked participants if there was an accessible way to locate office policies, for example, via a shared drive. We heard mixed messages as to whether this existed. It could be, similarly to communication writ large, that some units better communicated the location and access to policies while others did not. It is also important to note that based on discussions with the DAO research team regarding this, as of November 2021, the DAO has embedded a policy repository on their website. However, this finding is still worth mentioning as a potential misstep to be avoided by other jurisdictions. Additionally, at the time of this writing, some more recent policies are missing from the website (e.g., Bail Policy 2.0), underscoring the need for continuously updating the repository as new policies get adopted and/or modified.

4.1.4. Role of DATA lab

An initiative that DA Krasner started after taking office was the creation of the District Attorney's Transparency and Analytics Lab (DATA Lab), formally created in October 2019, which on its own is indicative of the administration's commitment to transparency and evidence-based policy. Not surprisingly, many respondents commented on the role of the DATA Lab and its stated mission, and generally showed support for their work. However, in regards to communication, we heard a clear desire to have more effective communication from the data team to better understand policy impacts, though some acknowledge that such efforts may be limited by data infrastructure limitations. Thus, participants did not always feel the DATA Lab was providing usable information to the people who most needed it for decision-making purposes. More specifically, ADAs in trial roles called for individualized outcome data to be communicated to them, so they know if the decisions they are making are achieving the office's stated goals. Or, if

they were not having that outcome, they could adjust how they go about their job.

For example, Participant 26 quoted in Table 2, expressed their desire to uphold stated office goals like reducing mass incarceration and mass supervision. However, they were not sure if their day-to-day decisions were working toward those goals. Since many staff were recruited to work for the DAO with the expressed purpose of reform efforts, assurances that their work is achieving these goals is very important. Another participant echoed this same sentiment to us:

There needs to be more review and data review of what kind of sentences are coming out of these rooms and to see that they are aligning with policy and circling back with supervisors to make sure they are doing everything they can to make sure policies are being respected and if not why. There are always deviations but if the middle of the bell curve is outside of where the policy is, that is a problem so there needs to be more transparent and structure and actual regular data review so that policies align with what is actually happening on the ground. (Participant 91, ADA, Trial).

4.1.5. Brief summary of communication

In sum, when participants were asked about communication, a pillar of progressive prosecution, sub-themes around policies and office operations emerged, highlighting the critical need to: provide opportunities for input from staff carrying out policies when developing them; consider how best policies can be rolled out to result in clear guidance to ensure success; to improve communication both office-wide and within-units; and use the DATA Lab to continue compiling and analyzing data for the organization as well as work toward providing prosecutors with data that can improve individual job performance.

4.2. Education & training

The second major theme related to organizational practices of the Philadelphia DAO surrounds staff education and training. Three sub-themes emerged from our interviews: the nature and substance of the training and the target recipients; the role of reassignments within the office; and difficulties in balancing the need and burden of training.

4.2.1. Nature/substance/recipients of training

Many respondents felt the training offered when first starting the job was helpful in orienting them and giving them a high-level view of the job. We were told this initial training discusses broad policy goals, system inequities the policies are meant to address, and generally provides an idea of what a progressive prosecutor is meant to be. For example, Participant 219 (ADA, Miscellaneous) said:

I know that mass supervision is a concept I wasn't familiar with until coming here and we were taught that early on. We were instructed on it when making plea deals. It's easy to see how two years of probation can become 5 or 10 years. I had a case where a guy was given two years in 2008 and now it's 2021 and he's still under supervision...They taught us about it early on and instructed us to keep that in mind when making deals.

This echoed other participants' views of the initial training. For example, Participant 14 (ADA, Trial), quoted in Table 3, comments favorably on the benefits of visiting a prison.

However, some people also felt that the training on progressive policies was a missed opportunity since all of the new ADAs came to work specifically for DAK. For example, Participant 68, an ADA in the law division, made the following comment: *Training is a real problem in this administration. There is very vague ideological training but not specific, technical training on how to do their job.* Similarly, Participant 193, pointed to limitations of the training due to its broad nature and no linkage to how they are to help line staff implement specific policies: *I think the training has gotten at the bigger ideas well but not connecting them up with our policies with how and why [the] office works certain ways. They*

Table 3
Overview of the education and training theme.

Subtheme	ID / Role	Representative Comments
Nature, Substance, and Recipients of Trainings	14 ADA	<i>I think education and training is being done and has a positive impact. Yes, I have been involved ... I did visit a holding cell. I think that can be helpful in terms of showing prosecutors where they are sending people.</i>
	19 Trial	<i>I know that they have had trainings for the bail policies, but they were for ADAs only so I wasn't there...The training is geared toward ADAs only. I would definitely like to know more about the policies so I know what I am talking about when people call and ask. Many other support staff could benefit from these trainings.</i>
	180 ADA	<i>They are edicts from on high, literally from the 18th floor [Executive offices], ...There are so many units so it is up to those units whether they actually implement it or not. It's a lot of here is the policy now do it instead of here is what we want you do in service of the policy. That inversion of conceptualizing how to implement any type of policy.</i>
	Misc.	<i>Any time someone moves to new units, you can't hand them a binder and say have at it champ. Each unit does very different things and there needs to be some kind of orientation...</i>
Role of Reassignments Within the Office	219 ADA	<i>...the ADAs getting placed in this unit [Guns/Shootings/Homicide] are young, they have been here for maybe 2 years, they do not feel like they are ready to go there, it is a very scary feeling to deal with these serious cases.</i>
	188 ADA	<i>...due to us being short staffed a lot of my training came through making mistakes working in the field when I wasn't ready. I know my supervisors will send out reminder emails if a case goes through that didn't follow policy.</i>
	188 Trial	
Balancing Need & Burden of Training	ADA	

went on to say: *Some were frustrated that they were very basic, because that class came in to work with Larry Krasner and they didn't need to be talked to for an hour about the 13th amendment.* Thus, individuals who expressed criticism that trainings were ideological felt that such trainings often left them without the necessary skills or preparedness to do their job. For example, when asked about the juvenile justice policy changes, one participant said:

People don't stay in juvenile long, so people don't get a lot of experience. Last time I was there, there was an ADA with no juvenile training and I had to show her how to put a gun into evidence. So they are not getting trained. (Participant 61, ADA).

From what we were told, and as evidenced by this quote, this kind of on-the-job training would typically be taken on by more experienced ADAs but with a lack of experienced attorneys in the office, few could take on that duty. Echoing the need for more training on juvenile policies, others indicated that some trainings could be maximized if offered across multiple units, as they are viewed as potentially beneficial across more units.

All in all, most comments related to the substance of the training underscore that while people may buy in to underlying progressive ideology, many respondents felt that the ideals may be challenging to implement in real life. Additionally, most comments also underscore the need for more specific targeting of recipients, as seemingly there is a divide in the staff comments along their hiring: ADAs who had been retained by the administration from the previous administration appreciated learning about the need for reform while recent hires expressed a clear desire for more hands-on training on how to implement progressive policies in their daily routines. Lastly, some participants, while reflecting on the staff training needs, took note of the fact that most if not all training is geared toward the legal staff only but that the non-legal, supporting staff could benefit as well, if included. For example, a member of the executive team told us:

I know that it [opportunities for site visits, etc.] happens for initial training of new lawyers. We could do a better job there too. We hire a ton of support staff and they don't get this experience and I think it would be good if they did (Participant 135, Other, Executive).

4.2.2. Role of reassignments within the office

Our respondents also felt that training inadequacy could be

particularly jarring when switching to new roles or new units within the office—problem exacerbated by staff shortages (see section on Staffing & Leadership below). Each unit comes with specific types of cases to be handled, as well as specific processes and procedures that ADAs felt they had to try and learn on their own. Participant 144, an ADA in the trial division, explained this sentiment to us:

I have found when you make a change in the office from one unit to another, there is not a lot of training that goes into that process. We have a several hundred-page binder, but the actual training process has lacked significantly.

In explaining their view, Participant 144 also echoed the sentiments above about the ideological nature of the training, and its limited usefulness in preparing ADAs for the actual work they will be doing in each unit, which can be magnified when one moves from one office unit to another during a short period of time. This can be further exacerbated when there are upticks in violence and serious offenses begin to account for a larger share of the caseload. Comments from two other participants, quoted in Table 3, express these frustrations arising from having to learn a difficult and stressful job on the job and while changing units frequently.

4.2.3. Balancing need & burden of training

Multiple people commenting on training needs circumscribed their comments with reflections on challenges involved in staff ability to participate in needed training due to competing demands on their job—especially problematic at a time of high turnover for the office and frequent reassignments, as discussed. One participant spoke to the additional burden staff shortages create for existing staff, especially in terms of ability to engage with training:

It [training] happens at some levels and the DA's office sponsors that. But when you're down by 25 % of your people it's hard to do anything that isn't the work on your desk. Everyone is just so overworked. More people would take advantage if they weren't so dog tired. (Participant 51, ADA).

In addition to commentary on training engagement, some of our participants also offered broader insights in terms of the office training needs, pointing to issues specific to an administration in transition, which involved hiring many new staff:

Much more training in this administration than previous. But also, because the work force is so new where the previous administrations were not nearly as new. So, you didn't need to train as many people in practice and procedure because you'd only get a couple of new people. (Participant 27, Other, Juvenile).

4.2.4. Brief summary of education and training

In sum, when participants were asked about the education and training pillar of progressive prosecution, the subthemes that emerged speak to the importance of the type of general training that organizations may consider (ideological and/or day-to-day job training) and the need for including targeted training (office-wide vs. unit-specific; attorneys vs. non-legal staff). Additionally, the unit-specific training offerings should account for office reassignments; more generally, our respondents' comments underscore the need to find the optimal balance of providing necessary education for organizational members without burning them out.

4.3. Staffing & leadership

An important component of the PPM guidelines centers on issues of staffing, as having staff aligned with the mission of the PPM is deemed essential for the success of progressive prosecutor-led reform. On the other hand, the literature also underscores the pragmatic need of retaining experienced prosecutors, seen as valuable in an organization in transition because of their role in carrying out regular tasks, their institutional knowledge, and their potential for informal mentoring of new staff. Thus, we asked our participants a range of questions relating to staff hiring, firing, and retention, and their responses provided valuable insights. The emerging sub-themes, summarized in Table 4, also speak to issues related to broader organizational management and leadership issues. Specifically, these include: initial firing; hiring and recruitment; diversity; organizational structure challenges; staff management; staff turnover; and leadership style.

Table 4
Overview of staffing & leadership theme.

Subtheme	ID / Role	Representative Comments
Initial Firing	57	<i>I have a few issues with that. One how do you measure who is amenable to change? they have made judgements about people based on prior administrations. But talk to those people, they might support the policies but don't think they are being trickled down to line staff in a meaningful way.</i>
	ADA Investigations	
	89	<i>Before I came in, I know he [DA] fired a bunch of people, I think it needs to happen again in my opinion. But there is not enough people to fill their spots now. There are at least 3 people in positions in authority who have no business being there. The supervisors of some units [redacted] made it incredibly difficult to work for.</i>
Hiring & Recruitment	104	<i>Of the new hires who came in, some are good, but some are confused about their role and are struggling to do their jobs.</i>
	ADA Law	
	57	<i>They have also hired a lot of prosecutors that aren't prepared to do the work so other people on the team are taking on more work because so many young attorneys that have never done the work before.</i>
Diversity	215	<i>I think this administration has done a good a job hiring people of color and queer people from different backgrounds, not just from the African American community.</i>
	ADA Investigations	
	57	<i>The internal policy team here is mostly white and [mostly] male. I think it changes. Other people have been brought to the table and they have said I'm allowed to sit there but my input isn't received at all. And this is all people internally in the office. So maybe they engage with a friendly council's office but how many stakeholders are meaningfully engaged?</i>
Organizational Structural Challenges	218	<i>My sense is that there was no org chart because part of the critique of the previous administration is that there were too many people with the title of Chief...but even today things that First Assistants should do they don't do.</i>
	ADA	
	205	<i>You have the inspiration to be successful and you have some staff to help drive you forward in line. Getting it nailed down is the hard part. We are disorganized, we don't have a chief of staff, we don't have an org chart.</i>
Staff Management	180	<i>It doesn't seem like leadership is great at foreseeing the need for meetings we have had so many meetings that are not related to policy that are sent at 9 am and the meeting is at 1 pm and it's mandatory. I have talked to colleagues, which makes it seem like they can't announce meetings with more than four hours' notice, like why we can't plan this.</i>
	ADA Miscellaneous	
Staff Turnover	205	<i>They won't do any exit interviews, [they are] not interested in learning why people leave. DAK doesn't seem to think there is anything wrong with the office and that is not why people are leaving.</i>
	ADA	
	87	<i>Office demands a lot but people are not compensated enough. For this administration, a lot of people are drawn here because they believe in it, but this can create an environment where people get burned out. There was a hiring freeze because of Covid, so now you are left with not many people.</i>
Leadership Style	135	<i>We have done a really good job of hiring a lot of people who are really here for the change. We have not done a good job of retaining them. We have not done a good job of maintaining them, because there are some people who are still here and not receptive to change and this creates internal office tension.</i>
	Other Executive	
	17	<i>I think things like "progressive", it's more so a label that people sell themselves to...That label has clouded this administration's judgement because they are trying to stick with it. I think they have good intentions, but it clouds your judgement when you're trying to serve your own individual office's interests.</i>

4.3.1. Initial firing

Soon after he took office, DA Krasner fired 31 existing ADA staff, representing about 10 % of the ADAs. Many people we interviewed referred to this initial firing to as “the mass firing.” Some people felt that the initial firing was necessary to implement desired policies. However, others believed the firing event ended up hurting DAO operations through the loss of institutional knowledge. Interestingly, this was a feeling shared by people who were supportive of the DA’s progressive vision and came to the office to work with him. They argued that while some staff needed to be fired, others were amenable to change and had reasons beyond their career that would support a change, such as their ties to Philadelphia. Participant 235 (ADA, Law) said: *What I see is that they made assumptions that there was a lot of ADAs that wouldn’t be receptive to change, and this was a bad idea, because they were life-long residents who would have been adaptable.* Participants 235, 57 (quoted in Table 4) and others felt this loss of institutional knowledge impacted the office’s ability to run units and implement new policies effectively. Participant 184 noted, for example, the consequence that the firing led to, *less experienced attorneys trying very serious cases.* (Participant 184, ADA, Pre-trial).

However, this was not a uniform opinion. Some individuals not only agreed with the initial firing but believed that more people should have been/need to be fired because they are not upholding the vision of the office. For example, for Participant 89, quoted in Table 4, the only hesitation with firing more people is the acknowledgment of the lack of experienced people to replace them. This sentiment was shared by DA Krasner, who when probed about the potential loss of institutional knowledge indicated that the knowledge that was lost was the kind he meant to rid the office of, namely, of those prosecutors who would have no qualms engaging in misconduct in order to secure convictions, at the expense of innocent people and office reputation. DA Krasner stated firmly that the records of these prosecutors, some of whom involved in the wrongful convictions/exonerations his office has pursued successfully, were a strong indicator that these prosecutors were “beyond” being amenable to change.

4.3.2. Hiring & recruitment

Comments regarding firing practices were often accompanied by commentary on hiring and recruitment. Some respondents questioned the effectiveness of office priorities, expressing the belief that many of the new hires were not prepared to be prosecutors. We heard numerous times throughout our interviews that people being recruited did not actually want to be prosecutors, and when the reality of the job hit them, they left. This sentiment was shared not only by people who have been in the system for many years, but even by their newly barred peers. We spoke with newly hired, fresh-out-of-law school ADAs who were very supportive of the progressive movement but also recognized the difficulty of reconciling this vision with the fact they still had to prosecute some people. Participant 144, a newly hired ADA in the trial division who came to work for DA Krasner, said this:

I don’t think it should be a blanket rule but there needs to be a real frank discussion that even if you’re a progressive prosecutor, prosecuting is still something you need to do. It’s still in the name. I think a lot of people thought he [DAK] would just snap his fingers and everything would change and I’ll never have to charge someone for small drug offenses. Then they are in the courtroom and they have to make a deal with someone.

This individual joined Philadelphia DAO driven by a desire to help implement progressive policies within the prosecutor’s office. Yet, they also came to recognize that at the end of the day, they are still a prosecutor and will need to charge, try, and convict some individuals—a reality they felt was not shared by all their peers who joined the office driven by similar progressive goals.

Some respondents who perceived the new hires to be struggling also associated their challenges with the leadership’s practice to recruit graduates from top Ivy League Schools. Participant 235, quoted above reflecting on the firing of people deemed amenable to change due to local roots if nothing else, went on to add: *And then hiring a bunch of people from around the country who weren’t ready to be a part of Philly.* (Participant 235, ADA, Law). Comments such as this reflect the perceptions staff retained from the previous administration and staff hired locally about the ability of the some of the new hires to do their job in a new city without prior knowledge/legal education about its local justice system. When given the opportunity to reflect and react to these findings, DA Krasner made a very persuasive case for his hiring strategy from law schools around the country, meant not only to secure top talent but also to increase diversity among ADAs on a variety of dimensions (an accomplishment acknowledged by his staff, see below). DA Krasner also acknowledged the significant role of local roots, particularly during the pandemic (our study’s timeframe) and emphasized that while the recruitment from the local schools dropped during his administration, most of the new recruits still come from the local schools and thus should have familiarity with the city of Philadelphia and its local criminal courts.

4.3.3. Diversity

We also asked our respondents about the extent to which the recruitment/hiring practices reflect a commitment to staff diversity, as recommended by the PPM. Almost every individual we spoke with knew the office had a goal of hiring a diverse staff and most felt the office was working toward that goal. Participant 61 (ADA) noted, *The diversity is definitely better; all the new hiring is more diverse.* However, some people had mixed feelings and believed the diversity in staff was primarily at the line level and not reflected in supervisory, managerial or policy positions. Take this reflection, for example: *I know that’s a big thing they try, on the attorney side I do see that as a concerted effort. They recruit from HBCUs. In positions that are not attorneys, I do not see diversity happening.* (Participant 41, Other). In contrast, Participant 63 (Paralegal) noted, *It [diversity] has been changed, there is a lot of diversity in leadership now. It has increased.*

Notably, some people of minoritized background spoke most pertinently on their perceptions about inclusion: *I would just say as a minority, if there are complaints about diversity, it’s not received well. They might just put a black person in a position and think that is enough* (Participant 5, ADA, Pre-trial). Lastly, some participants also felt that while a diverse staff was being hired, retention issues (discussed more broadly below) were particularly problematic for people of diverse backgrounds who may have arrived with certain expectations that were subsequently tempered. So, *DAK is very invested in hiring diverse and open-minded people. The problem is that those people have left in droves because once they get here they can’t use any discretion* (Participant 205, ADA).

4.3.4. Organizational structure challenges

A sub-theme that emerged very early in our data collection process regards the office’s organizational structure and related staff management. Interestingly, related insights were promoted by very different questions, ranging from establishing/confirming the respondent’s role within the organization to questions about overall internal challenges to questions about hiring and staff management. Thus, many people were stymied and expressed a great deal of frustration about the office’s perceived level of disorganization, starting with the intentional lack of an organizational chart and down to issues of staff mismanagement. For example, we encountered these kinds of reflections about the lack of an organizational chart: *There is no org chart which is confusing. I do not know if the person I mentioned in appeals is actually the assistant supervisor.* (Participant 248, ADA, Law). Some of our respondents themselves tried to provide a reasonable explanation for its absence, but whether or not

they felt that made sense, most people genuinely found it confusing to operate without an organizational structure chart in a 600-person organization. From the lens of an ADA, Participant 120's comments exemplify such an attempt to understand this organizational choice as well as the kind of frustration it generates:

Larry doesn't come from a background of being in a big office and I think he is skeptical of bureaucracy and he comes from this anarchist background...He doesn't want to have clear leadership because he doesn't want [people to take] ownership, but it leads to the opposite, there is a power vacuum. There are 3 people doing the same thing at the same time and not working together. It creates this silo. If people disagree on how things should be done, then they will just go on their own way and create what they want.

Another related issue that our respondents brought up—seen as rather unique to the Philadelphia DAO—is the fact that the DA had two First Assistants at the time of our study. Respondents speaking on this issue saw it as a dilemma and stated that they did not have a clear understanding of the delineations between their portfolios. Moreover, people reported perceptions of tension between the two, whether or not they actually witnessed anything of the sort, suggesting that the mere existence of two First Assistants made some employees believe that there must be some tension between the two. Participant 120, quoted above about the lack of organizational structure, went on to say: *Both of the first assistants don't talk to each other. There was a power struggle. Both of them had different ideas of what we should work on.*

It is notable that several of the respondents who made negative comments regarding the office's organizational structure also took note of DA's visionary platform, in a way implying that having such a transformational vision comes at a cost, including organizational challenges about figuring out how to implement it in practice. From executive lenses, Participant 77 (Other) noted, *"Larry is a visionary, he has good ideas, and he is getting a lot of things done, but the organization is in disarray,"* while Participant 134 (Other) stressed the need for a long-term leadership strategy, *"It would seem to me that we need a long-term strategy for building a leadership team that is going to survive us, be here after we're gone."*

Probed about the lack of an organizational chart and justifications for two First Assistants, the leadership team acknowledged that despite their original intent to simplify the chains of command, it has been problematic and challenging for the staff at large to function without a formal structural chart—which at the time of this writing has yet to be adopted. As for the potential for confusion arising from having two First Assistants with different or overlapping portfolios, this is no longer a concern as one First Assistant retired in 2023 and was not replaced.

4.3.5. Staff management

During our interviews, we also heard complaints about communication of internal office decisions related to staff management, meetings and organizational decisions. These complaints were related primarily to decisions to move staff from one unit to another and broader office decisions like returning back to work in person. For example, Participant 218 (Other) noted: *I can't be sure if the transfers are vindictive or if it's just incompetence, but people are transferred through an email without knowing about it and their supervisors don't know about it...*

4.3.6. Staff turnover

During the study's sampling and data collection period we came to find out that the office was experiencing significant staff turnover, which came up as a major source of concern among the people we interviewed. Investigating the perspectives of the staff leaving the office has

significant merit on its own⁸; however, here we focus on the concerns of the staff still working for DAO during the study timeframe, who have now found themselves having to cope with the consequences of the office's staff turnover and retention issues. Thus, many of our respondents noted these as significant problems for the functioning of the office. A variety of inter-related factors, exacerbated in a complex socio-historical time (e.g., global pandemic), were reported to contribute to the problems of staff turnover and retention. These include new hires deciding to leave the office/prosecutorial career/Philadelphia, coupled with the roles of inadequate or insufficient training, resignation of career prosecutors, and heavy workload and compensation concerns. Participant 180 (ADA, Miscellaneous), for example, spoke to the experiences of the new hires, *Post DAK hires leave from the crushing workload and the workload gets worse when people leave because it's still there and just distributed among fewer people which amplifies the effect*, while Participant 61 (ADA), expressed concerns about the loss of career prosecutors:

If you fire people who are resistant to your ideas, you have to consider what else you are losing. The supervisors now have very little trial experience and no one can train. The people that could have trained, have been fired or left. In the last 4 weeks we have had 4 experienced trial attorneys quit. (Participant 61, ADA).

As can be seen in both comments, our respondents are acutely aware of the negative, amplifying implications that the staff turnover has on remaining staff, in terms of their workload and ability to do their own job in a satisfactory manner, as well as office morale and working environment. Interestingly, for both the new hires and career prosecutors leaving the office, our respondents expressed the view that these individuals may have left because of feelings of inability to do the job according to own ethical standards—speaking more broadly to the potential clash between the office ideology and that of the staff, or, to the inability to implement the office ideology in practice despite embracing it in principle. Participant 242, an ADA in the law division, captures this in their comments about the new hires:

What changes people is a reality check, in the MC [Municipal Court] unit they are seeing really nasty things day in and day out... these other traditional law students are young and coming out of college and they are optimistic and never want to see anyone locked up and they spend the time talking with a violent rape victim and they become jaded over time. It is hard to maintain that broader idea of reform when you are smacked with 30–40 cases a day and seeing victims.

Our respondents also indicated that the leadership did not provide exit interviews as a matter of routine, and when they do occur (generally at the insistence of those leaving), they are usually missed opportunities for the office leadership to understand its own staff challenges and attempt to improve staff retention.

4.3.7. Leadership style

Another key sub-theme that emerged from our interviews under Staffing & Leadership is the leadership style. Some of our respondents, including people describing themselves as adhering to the office and

⁸ We considered the views of the staff who left the office at that time as critical in understanding the organizational challenges of the office—especially in the context of the national “great resignation” trends spurred by the pandemic. To this end, we made a concerted effort to capture their perspectives and we were able to reach a significant number of them through snowball sampling. However, given that their official affiliation was not with the DAO anymore during the data collection period (and that most of them had secured jobs with other external criminal justice stakeholders), we deemed this subgroup of the project's research subjects as a special sub-sample—worthy of analysis on its own. Their inclusion in the current analysis of internal staff might also bias the results as arguably they can be seen as among those most dissatisfied.

leadership ideology, described DA Krasner as a polarizing figure, prone to use what they perceived to be divisive language. Some took issue with the use of the term “progressive” in reference to the office and its policies. Consider, for example, the following: *I used to be regarded as one of the most progressive people on the floor and now I am considered the most traditional* (Participant 104, ADA, Law). Another way in which people felt unjustifiably and unhelpfully divided by the leadership was based off perceptions regarding the local vs. non-local hires, with the latter perceived to be considered by the leadership as more capable. The comments to this effect underscore the critical role of perceptions and language and context in amplifying potential misperceptions.

Equally important, some of our respondents were bothered by what they perceived to be a lack of trust by the leadership, which was seen to be manifested in multiple ways. Participant 174, for example, speaks to the office policy regarding requirements that staff seek approval to the very top for many of their decisions (presumably, as the leadership team clarified, these would also fall under policy deviations):

If we want to ask for a sentence on a certain case, we have to get approval because [DAK] doesn't want to release any of that control and be involved in as many cases as possible which is impossible with our case-loads. (Participant 174, ADA, Trial).

From the leadership perspective, the course of action described here can be seen as a natural consequence of the shrinkage of the organizational structure discussed earlier. However, as this quote illustrates, the line staff see such a top-down approach both as an impediment to their efficiency and as a lack of trust by the leadership, which in turns, engenders staff mistrust. Lastly, another way in which people felt that they were not trusted by their leadership was already described above, when presenting the findings on internal office communication on policy roll-out (i.e., people finding out about new policies last minute) and will become evident again below, as we present the findings on the Transparency & Accountability theme.

4.3.8. Brief summary of staffing and leadership

In sum, the sub-themes emerging under staffing and leadership highlight several needs for the Philadelphia DAO. One is to consider the nuances of firing persons who may be perceived as unamenable to progressive prosecution, in conjunction with recruitment of individuals who are talented and progressive-minded but that are willing and equipped to do the work of a prosecutor. Additionally, the findings underscored the office’s strong efforts to diversify the office, including in leadership positions. At the same time, the respondents’ comments point to the need for the leadership to develop a clear organizational structure that is mapped out, manage staff in ways that promote their

understanding of decisions and signal strong planning, understand reasons for staff turnover and work to retain talent, and reflect on the role that leadership style can have for office success and morale.

4.4. Transparency & accountability

We grouped the findings under this theme in three sub-themes: internal vis- vis external transparency; inconsistency in metrics; and role of DATA Lab.

4.4.1. Differences in internal transparency vs. external transparency

Many respondents highlighted the progress made by this administration, especially when looked at in contrast with previous administrations, in terms of transparency to the public. However, our respondents were also quick to note that the leadership’s focus on the external transparency is not matched internally. Participant 19 (Other) stated: *It seems that the focus on transparency is to the public. We have made progress in public transparency. In the office, I don't think we have achieved that.* The respondents’ perceptions about internal transparency were often linked to strong concerns about their ability to do their job effectively, such as the negative implications for the line staff to find out about policy roll out last minute or from external sources. More generally, our respondents expressed concern that the leadership’s focus on transparency to the media, in the form of its regular press conferences and media interviews/appearances, as well as preoccupation with city politics overshadows concerns for efficient organization functioning.

4.4.2. Traditional vs. progressive metrics/performance evaluations

A similar distinction emerged when we asked our respondents about the kinds of metrics that the DAO office uses to report its reform progress to the public and to evaluate the staff internally. For the purposes of the former, our interviewees reported that the office is using the kinds of metrics expected from a progressive administration. People pointed out, for example, official reports and statistics highlighting years of incarceration of supervision saved; or media reports and monitors around the main lobby of the office highlighting the office’s exoneration cases. However, for the latter purposes, of internal/staff performance evaluation, respondents indicated that the office continues to rely on the kinds of metrics traditionally relied upon by prosecutorial offices, such as conviction rates. Take, for example, the following insights:

I think again there is a mismatch between the things we talk about in public and what the DATA Lab is doing and what is being done in the office, like how ADAs are being held accountable in their own units... They are definitely still using the metric of getting guilty verdicts, pleas to a long sentence is great for you. But if you withdrew for some reason, lost an

Table 5
Overview of transparency and accountability.

Subtheme	ID / Role	Representative Comments
Differences in Internal vs. External Transparency	218 Other	<i>Sometimes there were press conferences to release policies before people in the office knew about it because there was concern that policies were going to be leaked.</i>
Traditional vs. Progressive Metrics/ Performance Evaluations	122 ADA Juvenile	<i>Man, this [expletive] is deep. No one would ever say that. That wouldn't be how you were officially evaluated but it was a part of the culture. It was unsaid. Unspoken.... I feel like I've been here a long time... No one said they were judging you on wins and losses and you do what you need to get the convictions. I don't know how you measure what you're talking about ["progressive metrics"] either, it's a hard [expletive] job and to me</i>
		<i>the biggest question is the risk. Are you going to take a chance on someone or not? The consequences for that can be serious on both ends.</i>
Role of District Attorney's DATA Lab	51 ADA	<i>Through the evaluation we were able to see that supervision lengths had been reduced by about 25% and racial disparities had been minimized. That doesn't answer the question entirely, but our office has been able to see that there is some reduction.</i>

appeal, or [get] a not guilty verdict [it] will be bad for you. (Participant 193, ADA, Trial).

As the additional quote in the Table 5 demonstrates (from Participant 122), as much as the staff is concerned with how they are evaluated and how their cases are seen as wins or losses, what weighs even more heavily on them are the real-life consequences of their high-stakes decisions.

During the interview with the research team, DA Krasner acknowledged the challenging task of developing internal means of evaluating individual performances consistent with the progressive goals of the office that can also tap into the great variety of tasks that line staff are expected to undertake on a regular basis without compromising fairness to the staff. He highlighted several challenges in this regard, including how to account for the vast differences in caseload type (e.g., homicides vs. misdemeanor cases) and volume (e.g., high vs. low) across the office units, as well as the frequent staff transitions among units.

4.4.3. Role of district attorney's transparency analytics (DATA) lab

The office's DATA Lab appeared prominently in our respondent's reflections whenever we asked about the office's commitment to transparency and accountability, especially praising its role in interfacing with the public via the DAO data dashboard that the lab created, and the periodic research reports it conducted and released on various topics or reforms undertaken by the office. In addition to highlighting the role of the DATA Lab as instrumental in showcasing the office's policy effects, as seen in the quote in Table 5, some employees also derived a sense of pride and satisfaction in being able to see the impact of policies via data-driven evaluations.

4.4.4. Brief summary of transparency and accountability

In sum, participants raised the importance of having internal transparency within the office in addition to transparency outside of the office, considering ways to measure the individual performance of a "progressive" prosecutor to match strong efforts to report on organizational achievements, and continue using the DATA Lab to release reports and communicate effectiveness of policies.

4.5. COVID-19 pandemic related challenges

Given the focus of the study on organizational context and processes, with any of the themes above we also probed about the potential conflating effects of the pandemic-related restrictions. We found that just as most people and places experienced a great deal of challenges related to the Covid-19 pandemic, the DAO was no exception. Most insights regarding the pandemic effects involved communication, training, and staffing. Thus, staff members reported that communication was impacted by the pandemic interrupting routines, lines of communication and the ability to hold meetings. When asked if staff ever all got together, one participant said:

Not yet. We might have gone back to doing that stuff, but the pandemic has been about survival. Thankfully we haven't lost anyone of our staff [to COVID]. We've been about who should be at work and who should be home. With Omicron we had 50 people out for that. When you have 100 resignations in a year, you're really trying to get through to the next day. (Participant 134, Other, Executive).

This sentiment was shared in relation with communication with external partners in the community as well. While acknowledging that over the course of the pandemic, the staff were largely restricted from in-person events that allow for quality face-to-face interactions necessary to build trust, participants also expressed optimism as they saw these restrictions beginning to alleviate, which in turn would open the door for greater engagement.

Another area in which participants highlighted the disruptive role of the COVID-19 pandemic restrictions regarded training. The following

quote reflects this: *There was some training when I was here before COVID that touched on broad issues. I have not seen that training kept up* (Participant 231, ADA, Investigations). In conversations with the DAO leadership, the research team learned that some of the in-person trainings have resumed, yet the executive team also acknowledged the continued need for more effective and targeted trainings, as mentioned when presenting findings on this theme.

Lastly, we were particularly curious as to the pandemic effects on issues of staffing. As noted above, during the pandemic/study time-frame, the office experienced a great deal of staff turnover, whose effects on individual caseload and office morale were compounded even more by the hiring freeze imposed by the city at the time. This being said, it is worth noting that most respondents who offered reflections on people's potential reasons for leaving the office held strong the belief that their colleagues' decisions to leave were primarily driven by their overall dissatisfaction with the organization, and only secondarily by reasons related to the pandemic. In his interview, DA Krasner emphasized the recent success of his recruiting efforts and indicated that currently the office has made up for what he described as the pandemic-related staff shortage.

5. Discussion

The interviews with DAO staff provided many takeaways of best practices as they relate to the implementation guidelines. Based off the findings, we present key recommendations in terms of each of the four pillars for prosecutorial offices wishing to newly implement, or improve ongoing implementation of, a progressive agenda.

5.1. Communication: implications & recommendations

Findings revealed that careful consideration needs to be given to communication in all forms. The findings from our interviews echo those reported by Richardson and Kutateladze (2021) in their qualitative study in Florida, on two other reform-minded prosecutorial offices. In their interviews they found that ambiguous or unclear communication contributed to inconsistent messaging about goals and priorities. The findings also corroborate with the results from the recent survey conducted by Ward et al., 2025 with a larger sample of Philadelphia DAO staff, which too highlighted insufficient clarity regarding policy guidance. Taken together, our study's findings underscore the continued need for meaningful and authentic efforts to engage with staff throughout the policy implementation process to improve perceptions of intra-agency communication.

To start with, the staff noted a very strong desire not to feel left in the dark with regard to policy rollouts. Official policy changes should be communicated in a timely manner and staff expected to be directly impacted by it should be informed of changes before the rollout is announced to other actors they may interact with in the course of their duties (e.g., judges). We understand that from the leadership perspective communicating policy changes at times might need to be balanced against the risk that the release of information might be used to undermine the application of an intended policy. However, weighed against the concerns raised by the staff ranging from frustration to inability to do their job effectively and feelings of mistrust, this conflict speaks to the clear need for DAO leadership to balance the concerns about potential leaks against both the risk of weaker/inefficient implementation and the very high possibility (and costs) of weakening or even losing the trust of its staff. In short, timely communication of policy rollouts could help alleviate feelings of confusion and stress, would promote trust in the organization, and would allow employees to more effectively implement the policies.

Staff also noted a clear desire for more and genuine opportunities for input. We recommend encouraging two-way communication between staff and leadership when it comes to policy development and implementation. It is especially important to include input from employees

who have experience directly working on the types of cases affected by a policy. Staff feedback on implementation may reveal certain patterns that may be helpful in guiding policy alterations. Of course, in such a large organization it is not always possible to have direct two-way communication with all employees, thus it is important to capitalize on the role of unit managers. Supervisors can help increase trust and legitimacy when they have trust in upper leadership.

In our findings, the DATA Lab was viewed in a strong positive light and this entity played a key role in successful communication. We urge the Philadelphia DAO to continue to use the lab as a source of communication for the office and suggest that other jurisdictions create and utilize a similar type of data unit. Going one step further, the comments from some of our respondents suggest the DAO would benefit greatly from moving beyond using high-level, aggregate data and metrics (such as years of incarceration avoided) to more targeted personalized feedback on individual-case level data that can help line ADAs in court decisions. Admittedly, this is much easier said than done, especially with limited resources and given the various dimensions that need to be considered for inclusion in potential personalized feedback (e.g., workload volume and type). Nonetheless, with improved case management systems, such an effort is worth pursuing as it would assist ADAs in realizing the progressive goals of the office and strengthen their buy-in to office policies (in addition to providing a means for evaluating/tracking individual performance).

5.2. Education & training: implications and recommendations

At the onset, it is important to recognize how training can lead to shared orientations toward progressive prosecution work across the agency. Previous research found that DA office employees with different orientations prioritized different processes and outcomes (Lowrey-Kinberg et al., 2022; Meldrum et al., 2021). In our study, interviewees provided useful feedback regarding trainings focused on the ideology of the progressive agenda—generally recommended by the PPM guidelines. These trainings speak to the vision for the office and should primarily be targeted toward staff that is more traditionally oriented. Attorneys with a long career, or those trained to have a more traditional approach will likely benefit the most from learning about the harms of traditional prosecution and how to correct them. On the other hand, as we heard from many of our respondents, new hires, many who have been recruited and already sharing the agency vision at the time of hiring, will rather need more hands-on and experiential training on how to be progressive prosecutors in action. Particular care needs to be given to educating staff on how to navigate and reconcile the traditional adversarial role expected of them in court by other legal actors with their newly envisioned role upholding progressive approaches. It is critical that those eager to do the work of progressive prosecution are given the tools and are equipped with the skills to implement this in action; otherwise, in the absence of needed support, as our findings suggest, they might become disillusioned, or even want to leave the organization altogether.

Training efforts should not just focus on onboarding, but also on continued education, including as part of personnel transfer to new units/divisions. The criticism and frustration we heard from some of our respondents that they had to learn the job by doing it and making mistakes underscores the critical role that mentoring could have in the transmission of knowledge. While some informal mentoring may take place organically in some units (underscoring again the critical role of the supervisory capacity), ideally the office would seek to implement a formal mentoring program, which could be particularly beneficial when transfers occur. In addition, informal mentoring groups can facilitate beneficial exchanges of ideas between those who are embracing progressive ideals and those embracing a more traditional vision of their role as prosecutors.

As much as the staff lamented the need for training, they also acknowledged that, in the context of their workload and staff shortages,

sometimes the burden of the training outweighed its need. This prompts the recommendation that the trainings be optimized such that they are held during times/days that would ensure wide availability and participation among the target staff. Additionally, targeting and tailoring training based on needs of specific units/transfers would not only help with optimization, but such differentiation between unit-specific and office-wide trainings would likely increase receptivity to content material among attendees. Lastly, based on comments we heard from non-legal/support staff, there is also a need for some adaptation of the policy trainings offered to ADAs that would target the supportive staff and would enable them to be more efficient with their assistance.

5.3. Staffing & leadership: implications and recommendations

Interviewees gave valuable feedback regarding staffing and leadership. To start with, it is critical to recognize the value for new progressive chief prosecutors of surrounding themselves with staff that aligns with their vision. It is important to acknowledge that this notion—of bringing in new staff and firing old staff—is commonplace in the United States among any newly elected offices, prosecutorial ones included. This notion, more generally, is consistent with general organizational leadership practices. Lastly, we should also recognize the role of organizational inertia and the opposition it engenders, to anything seen as too disruptive/diverging with longstanding practice in possibly prompting some of the comments from some respondents. The literature on organizational change has long recognized such inertia as a major barrier to organizational change (Carrillo & Gromb, 2007; Kelly & Amburgey, 1991; Liao, Fei, & Liu, 2008), including in criminal justice settings, prosecutorial offices included (Campeau, 2019; Sklansky, 2018). It is within this context that the findings from our study regarding both the initial firing and the office recruitment strategy need to be interpreted. Thus, all in all, people we interviewed disagreed on the potential benefit of the initial firing and had mixed feeling on the office's recruitment strategy, yet most saw benefits in retaining experienced prosecutors.

Many of the respondents amplified what they saw as potentially negative consequences of the initial firing that occurred when DA Krasner took office. While some of them could not see the merits of firings based on what they perceived to be purely ideological grounds, they did raise the valid point of potential amenability to change among those who may not have shared the same values as the DA. The validity of this point becomes more apparent in light of the study's findings regarding (a) the high levels of staff turnover experienced during the study timeframe, and (b) especially the loss of experienced attorneys, seen by some as critical in providing informal mentoring and passing on institutional knowledge. Taken together, this points to the need and recommendation that progressive chief prosecutors place great emphasis on staff retention, including staff from the previous administration that at first may be considered as not sharing the vision of the new administration. Given staffing issues and office needs in context—that the office needs to be ready to do its business on day one while the transition in leadership and staffing happens—our findings suggest that newly elected chief prosecutors may wish to come in with the presumption that most existing staff is amenable to change, and make attempts to educate and train before firing. In sum, our study underscores the need in a large prosecutorial organization in transition for the leadership to secure buy-in of the progressive vision of a significant portion of the more experienced staff who would continue to carry on some of the most difficult prosecutorial tasks (e.g., trials) and could take on the mantle of passing on some needed institutional knowledge to new hires via formal or informal mentoring.

Regarding the recruitment strategy, while many participants showed an appreciation for the diversity in hiring, there were perceptions of an increased focus on recruiting from non-local law schools—including Ivy Leagues and Historically Black Colleges and Universities. As evidenced in our data, and acknowledged by the leadership, hiring attorneys who

did not have local roots could have contributed to the staff turnover during our study timeframe. More generally, our respondents made the case that non-local employees have insufficient knowledge about the city and its agencies' operations, and less investment in the local community, thus rendering them less effective in their ability to do their job. On the other hand, we also heard first-hand from DAO leadership about the benefits of hiring from non-local schools, especially in terms of enriching the office diversity—which was also noted by the staff. Considering all this, it could be useful to more explicitly message to the existing staff the rationale for a chosen recruiting strategy. Equally important, given that new attorneys will be coming from various types of law schools and various locations, it is important for leadership to intentionally employ inclusive language as to not leave some groups feeling excluded.

Relatedly, although most of our respondents expressed positive views regarding the office's effort to increase its diversity, it is notable that some of our respondents of minoritized status perceived a problem that is common among institutions committed to diversity efforts, and documented by research (Dover, Kaiser, & Major, 2020; Myers & Dreachslin, 2007): that having a diverse workforce cannot be automatically equated with inclusiveness, and that even with successful hiring strategies, low retention, stemming from perception of lack of inclusion, remains a persistent issue. Lastly, our findings underscore the need for leadership to encourage genuine feedback from the staff who decide to leave, via exit interviews. These conversations enable learning from potential mistakes and better understand staff issues, and guide efforts to retain staff.

We would be remiss if in our discussion of staff turnover and retention we do not discuss the confounding effects of the COVID-19 pandemic, during which our data were collected. This is a time where some of the newly hired staff abruptly found themselves in lockdown in a place in which they did not have the time and opportunities to build any meaningful social connections—thus a move back to their home base might have had greater appeal than otherwise. When probed about the role of the pandemic in explaining the potential staff turnover, our respondents were consistent in their perceptions that the pandemic was not the primary reason for their colleagues leaving the office—and that factors related to other themes emerged in this study, such as insufficient organizational support and ability to do their jobs adequately and derive satisfaction from it—were much more prominent. All in all, it is difficult to disentangle from the study's data analyzed here the extent to which the staff turnover experienced by the DAO during the study timeframe was due to larger societal shifts, such as the oft-discussed “great resignation” (Fuller & Kerr, 2022). It is also worth noting that Philadelphia DAO fits within the larger national picture when it comes to prosecutorial vacancies and, more generally, staff retention and turnover in the legal professions (Gershowitz, 2023).

Regarding staff management more broadly, overall, participant answers revealed some dissatisfaction around organizational and structural challenges that in their view contributed to confusion and inefficiency. People's comments on the organizational structure and leadership of the office suggests a strong need for a clear-cut chart outlining who oversees what and who reports to whom. Although there may be some valid reasons behind the intentional decision to operate without a chart, the large size of the organization and strengths of the concerns, frustration, and confusion expressed by our respondents provide strong reasons for reconsidering this decision regarding the organization's formal structure. The chart may be updated as needed, as new units or sub-units may be created to respond to new office priorities (e.g., creation of units dedicated to specific crime, such as retail theft).

Lastly, our respondents offered important insights regarding what they saw as issues related to the leadership style. In a way, the nature of these comments, centered on the role of language and narrative as a divisive factor, reflect the current national state of extreme polarization in American politics and policy discourses, which is also evident in elections for DAs. People we interviewed pointed out numerous times

that in the context of their prosecutorial job, the use of labels to ascribe ideological values can be counterproductive and inductive to unnecessary conflict, misperceptions, and mistrust among the staff and vis-à-vis the leadership. In light of these reflections, and given that prosecutors are all bonded by their commitment to public service, a natural recommendation here is that it would be more productive to try to achieve alignment of values and, subsequently, approaches to implement them, by focusing on the common ground and shared values that prosecutors uphold, whether or not they see themselves, or as seen by others, as “progressive” or “traditional”.

5.4. Transparency & accountability: implications and recommendations

Findings from the questions on the transparency and accountability pillar revealed insights on how to enhance these goals. These findings also tie into the results we discussed earlier, regarding communication, that is, good communication is transparent communication. Looking toward external transparency, our interviews revealed that the DATA Lab's work on sharing data with the public, stakeholders and research community is seen as a valuable transparency tool. Data units can increase transparency by leveraging relationships with external partners and directly communicating with the community. Their work toward this aim should emphasize the appropriate means to message information, depending on the intended target audience—e.g., information would need to be distilled in different ways for the community/the public at large versus criminal justice partners. In line with this aim, DAO should continue to update the publication of its policies, and of their revisions, if applicable, on the website.

Our study presents a more mixed picture when it comes to the office's efforts regarding internal transparency, pointing to an increased need for enhancing transparency and accountability so that these components become integral to the office culture. Harkening back to some of the issues we discussed above regarding communication and policy rollout, ideally, staff should feel like they have trust in their leadership and the leadership should feel that they can trust their staff to promote through their work the progressive values embodied by the organization. Participants also shared that they wanted more transparency around performance evaluations regarding meeting progressive goals; as indicated earlier, they saw the role of personalized feedback as a mechanism to help them visualize the results of their work and their own contribution to achieving the office mission. As we already mentioned above, DAOs should consider the development, use and tracking of progressive metrics for individual-level performance evaluations. This said, this would be a major undertaking requiring both agreement on what the core progressive metrics should be and investment in case management and infrastructure for data collection, analysis, and reporting.

As a concluding note under the Transparency & Accountability theme, it is important to also highlight the impressions of the research team conducting this study. It is reasonable to state, based on the researchers past experiences, that the office openness to research is unmatched in the recent history of the Philadelphia DAO administrations. The office's engagement in various research partnerships at the local and national levels as well as the development, for the first time in the history of the office, of a data and analytic capacity dedicated to publicizing the office's reform progress also came up as a point of pride during our interview with DA Krasner. Arguably, the level of access granted to our research team to the entire DAO staff, in full awareness that the purpose of the study was to probe in depth into the office's organizational practices and challenges, is truly unprecedented. Most often, in such studies, the leaders of an organization hand-pick several staff they trust with participating in the study, which is often seen as a research limitation since the results are subject to bias suspicion. Not only was this not the case here, but as the sample size of our study indicates, many staff felt fully free to participate, and as the nature of their comments suggest, many felt fully free to express negative views toward

the office. Indeed, by allowing this level of access, the office opened itself up to possible scrutiny. In short, all this to us is indicative of the DAO leadership's extraordinary commitment to the promise of transparency and accountability of the progressive prosecution movement, which is quite laudable and serves as a model for other agencies around the nation wishing to embrace this core guideline pillar in practice as it relates to research-practitioner partnerships.

6. Conclusions

This study set out to analyze whether and how the prescriptive guidelines of the progressive prosecution movement that focus on changing the organizational culture are being reflected in the operations of the Philadelphia DAO, and what lessons can be taken from the experiences of internal stakeholders to promote effective policy implementation and significant system reform. We found that at the time of this study the organizational and operational practices of the DAO were partially consistent with the prescribed guidelines with notable room for improvement across each pillar. We believe the findings and recommendations from our study can contribute to bettering practices for other DAOs wishing to implement progressive policies. Acknowledging that the findings show that the Philadelphia DAO is doing many things toward the achievement of the agenda it set out for itself in terms of changing the culture of the organization, including for example, efforts to diversify staff and collecting and sharing aggregate-level data with the public, we purposefully focused our discussion on areas for improvement. Our recommendations are meant to provide actionable items to help improve office functioning and implementation of PPM policies and serve as a resource for other jurisdictions experiencing problems similar to those uncovered in our study.

The PPM is thought to be a major criminal justice reform movement. The political nature of DA elections will naturally inject division among ideologues—and narratives of this division were echoed in our respondent's comments. Given that such ideological demarcations may impede prosecutorial offices to function efficiently, it is critical that leaders of the PPM be mindful about how to best message the vision of the movement without creating alienation and division among staff tasked with carrying out the vision—and potentially with external stakeholders, as well. Internal staff are the most vested stakeholders in any organization—which is partly why we focused on them here—and implementation science has documented the critical role that stakeholder support and cooperation plays in achieving intended policy goals (Guevara & Solomon, 2009; Lin, 2002).

Our findings also revealed that the reality of the day-to-day practice of being a prosecutor often stood in conflict with some core policies of a progressive prosecutorial agenda, such as those aiming to limit the footprint of the legal system by targeting sources of mass incarceration and mass supervision (via plea bargaining, sentence recommendations, etc.). Some respondents who shared the office vision were disheartened by the reality of the job; some found themselves hardened by dealing with horrific crimes and traumatized victims. Thus, it is critical that PPM leaders—and movement organizations providing guidelines and blueprints—successfully address the lingering questions about how to reconcile the expected role of the prosecutor under the progressive vision with the tasks generally expected of the prosecutor in the American adversarial legal system.

The role of the progressive prosecutor is also sensitive to external pressures. Sustaining a progressive agenda can be difficult under external pressures such as spikes in violent crime trends or negative narratives in the media. In our study, respondents were sensitive to the fact that the media was contributing to a narrative that DAO policies were responsible for any uptick in crime. At the individual level, these external pressures can cause attorneys to change their practices. At the organizational level, such pressures may lead to significant changes in policy altogether. The implication of these external influences is that leadership needs to proactively communicate and provide very clear

guidance to line staff on potential courses of action and deviations from presumptive policy, and update trainings on any revised policies. Externally, staying on top of external transparency and communication, and providing up-to-date statistics to external stakeholders and the public is essential in combating any potential misconceptions.

Lastly, we used the prescriptive PPM guidelines to frame our work, and our findings raise some questions about the full extent of their usefulness to chief prosecutors wishing to pursue progressive agendas. The four organizational-related pillars we analyzed here, gleaned from such literature – communication; education and training; leadership and staffing; and transparency and accountability – are all desirable features to pursue. Our study suggests, however, that the reality on the ground may make some of these guidelines look too idealistic, or at least incomplete, and that some chief prosecutors may benefit greatly from more specificity that accounts for the local context and external pressures.

For example, under the leadership pillar, much of the guidelines center around generic leadership approaches, and do not necessarily speak to the struggles that the most progressive DAs may find themselves facing once they start rocking the boat. Here, we suggest that the guidelines be enhanced by borrowing from the literature on transformational leadership in achieving organizational change. There are numerous challenges to changing organizational culture, not the least of which inertia, as we mentioned above, and leaders need to be equipped to deal with it. Transformational leaders embody characteristics such as influence, individualized consideration, intellectual stimulation, and inspirational motivation (Ghasabeh, Soosay, & Reaiche, 2015). While some progressive DAs may naturally embody these characteristics, all those who wish to pursue consequential reform could themselves benefit from training or coaching on how to be transformational leaders, so that they more fully succeed in motivating change in harder-to-reach staff and external partners. Research has found that a leader's ability to motivate, communicate, and build teams predict successful implementation when an organization is undergoing change (Gilley, McMillan, & Gilley, 2009). In the case of progressive DAs, transformational leadership can motivate those who are most unlikely to be onboard with a progressive approach and re-invigorate those who are already on board.

To be clear, some of the issues related to the implementation context we identified in this study may not be unique to the PPM and may be relevant to any prosecutorial-led reform efforts. However, the PPM offers specific guidelines that allow for analysis of an overall implementation framework of a progressive agenda—and here we focused on four main pillars. This being said, the study findings do suggest that prosecutorial offices and chief prosecutors who openly embrace a “progressive” agenda and its label, may face some unique challenges, related for example, to the role of ideological narratives underlying the reform, role of large-scale staff changes during the transition process, as well as the role of leadership style as a driving force for PPM.

6.1. A note of research to action

As indicated, our partnership with DAO on this project also included several meetings with the office's leadership and research teams, focused on discussion of findings and potential recommendations. As we were completing our manuscript, we checked in with the office to see if progress has been made in any of the areas needing improvement that we identified. Thus, in addition to some of the changes mentioned in the discussion section (e.g., increase in training offerings since the study timeframe), several additional efforts are noteworthy, as they stem directly from this study and the research-to-action meetings. These include:

- To increase meaningful opportunities for staff input into policy discussion (under Communication), office-wide policy meetings were moved from Friday afternoons to Wednesday afternoons, with

anecdotal evidence of increased staff engagement. These meetings now also have greater representation from the DATA Lab, which sees clear value in being directly involved in conversations with DAO line staff.

- Allowing unit supervisors to decide whether trainings are relevant for their respective staff and require participation. This responds to our recommendation under Training & Education for maximizing training and capitalizing on the role of unit supervisors. Regarding the nature and impact of training, we also discussed the development of a pre-/post-hire survey to determine potential attitude changes and shifts in staff/vision and alignment with the office vision.
- Important changes have also been reported relevant to the study findings regarding Leadership & Staffing. We highlight here the creation of a new Trial Deputy role, in charge of managing trial resources, including staff caseloads/workloads and as already indicated, the office consolidated the responsibilities of the two First Assistants into a single individual, eliminating an important potential source of confusion among staff.
- Lastly, there are several ongoing initiatives undertaken by the DATA Lab that aim to both increase office/staff efficiency as well as internal and external transparency. To name a few, the lab is now generating automated reports on early bail reviews that are sent to line prosecutors, with the goal of expanding the use of such reports to other critical decision stages in the legal process. Similarly, the lab is generating weekly reports on court continuances, again meant to help ADAs manage their caseload more efficiently. Importantly, responding to the recommendations to provide prosecutors individualized feedback on their cases/outcomes, the lab is developing and is in the process of piloting an “ADA snapshot” to be shared regularly with prosecutors. These are some of the initiatives already undertaken. Importantly, others are in various stages of development and to be successful would necessitate intensive resource allocations and significant upgrades in case management and infrastructure systems.

In sum, all these are indicative of DAO’s commitment to reform implementation success while also underscoring the value of research-practitioner partnerships to guide policy implementation.

6.2. Limitations & future research directions

The study is not without limitations. The timing of the data collection (summer 2021 to summer 2022) likely had a major impact on respondent’s thoughts and experiences. Not only was this during the end of first term of the new DA/re-election for second term and it is likely that some policies were not fully settled in, but the effects from the Covid-19 pandemic were still apparent. We discussed above the potential effects on staff turnover. In addition, the court system was impacted by being shut down and then changing to virtual proceedings, with in-person hearings reopening in Spring 2021, before our data collection started. This created severe backlog and attorneys were inundated with cases. Being overworked and not having traditional in-person spaces to connect and communicate surely limited the ability to successfully implement organizational and structural changes—and potentially our respondent’s perceptions regarding the office functioning. There is also a need to be mindful of self-selection bias. In this case it is possible that those who were most dissatisfied were more likely to want to participate. Further, humans have a natural tendency to overemphasize or focus more on the negative (Rozin & Royzman, 2001). Nonetheless, our sample was representative of the target population with respect to sex, gender and division. Moreover, we intentionally did not include in the current study analysis of interviews with employees who left the organization during the study period. While we believe there are important takeaways from those interviews, their exclusion here was meant to reduce any potential source of bias resulting from their presumably greater lever of dissatisfaction.

The PPM is still in its early stages, and tracking the development of

these reform efforts is an important area for future research. Research on implementation and organizational culture needs to be conducted over time with follows up. While snapshots are informative, studying policy implementation during a major reform era involves ongoing efforts and highlighting points of success and improvement needs in close-to-real time would be most beneficial. Case studies such as this study provide feedback to the local organization and suggestive guidance to others wishing to implement changes. To further this understanding, research on progressive prosecution should conduct cross-jurisdictional comparisons. Comparing the Philadelphia DAO with other DA offices will highlight how local context may affect policy implementation and illuminate the potential role of different leadership styles in effecting organizational change. Another important consideration when making cross-jurisdictional comparisons must take into account that, as Participant 77 noted, the Philadelphia DA is a “huge office”, and large agencies by their very nature may experience unique or complex challenges in relation to each of the four pillars guiding progressive prosecution efforts. Research we discussed earlier (Grodensky et al., 2023), done in a much smaller office, suggest that in small-size offices, staff unity around policy goals and approaches to implementation is rather easy to achieve; such a jurisdiction may not face the same challenges we uncovered in Philadelphia DAO when it comes to internal communication/policy rollout. On the other hand, a small size office may fare worse on other PPM implementation pillars. For example, small offices may not have the same capacity to invest in a research lab/data dashboard, as Philadelphia DAO does, which greatly enhances transparency to public. More generally, for external validation, future research should explore prosecutorial offices adherence to PPM guidelines across a range of different size organizations (small-to-medium-to-large) to uncover variation that may exist in their ability to follow the PPM guidelines closely and the sources of variation.

Lastly, our research was exploratory in nature. Deductively, we guided the study based on the prescriptive literature on PPM and intentionally we focused on issues with great relevance for policy implementation, striving to provide immediate recommendations to Philadelphia DAO. This being said, most of the study’s findings emerged inductively based on the participants’ answers and their responses suggests other potentially fruitful avenues of research, such as theory testing and drawing on theoretical frameworks that may go beyond the literature on progressive prosecution. One possibility, for example, would be the application of the “inhabited institutions” framework that Ulmer (2019) proposed to study criminal courts (and especially sentencing practices), which could be extrapolated to prosecutorial offices (and other criminal justice agencies). Under this perspective, institutions are seen from the “bottom-up” (rather than as top-down structures), inhabited by individual actors and communities whose interactions converge to form the organizational culture. The qualitative nature of our data and its focus on individual-level perceptions of organizational context renders the data for fruitful potential analysis examining the applicability of the inhabited institutions perspective to a prosecutorial office setting. In a similar vein, it would be theoretically relevant to determine to what extent the shifts in prosecutorial operational practices brought about by the PPM changes our understanding of the “courtroom communities” and “courtroom workgroup” dynamics and, more generally, how such shifts may challenge the theoretical underpinnings of the established courts-as-organization literature (Eisenstein, Flemming, & Peter Nardulli, 1988; Eisenstein & Jacob, 1977).

In the end, this study focuses on attorney, executives and other staff perceptions of communication, education and training, leadership and staffing, and transparency and accountability in the Philadelphia DAO during the time of study—in an effort to capture this organization’s adherence to core PPM implementation guidelines. These perceptions are important per se and provide valuable insights into both successes and challenges when implementing a progressive reform agenda. Importantly, the Philadelphia DAO is already making changes to certain

procedures and innerworkings of the office based on this research, as alluded to above, which underscores a strong commitment to transparency and accountability and efforts to improve processes where feasible.

Declaration of generative AI

No generative AI was used in the writing of this manuscript.

Funding statement

This research was made possible by Arnold Ventures who provided support for a mixed-methods evaluation of prosecutor-led criminal justice reform in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania. The authors are grateful for the funding which was critical for facilitating the research activities leading to this publication. Any opinions, results, conclusions, or recommendations expressed in this manuscript belong to the authors and do not necessarily reflect the views of Arnold Ventures.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

E. Rely Vîlcică: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Supervision, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Megan E. Mohler:** Writing – original draft, Validation, Software, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Jesse Brey:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Validation, Software, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Jeffrey T. Ward:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Supervision, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization.

Declaration of competing interest

We have no known conflict of interest to disclose.

Acknowledgements

We thank members of the District Attorney Transparency Analytics (DATA) Lab as well as all attorneys and staff in the Philadelphia District Attorney's Office for their participation in this research. We also acknowledge the efforts of the larger research team that contributed to the development of this research, especially Drs. Caterina Roman and Peter Jones, and those whose contributions included data collection/ conducting of interviews: Dr. Cheryl Guynn-Irons, Cathy Rosen, and Cheyenne Dolbear.

Appendix A. Philadelphia DAO semi-structured interview: Core protocol sections

INTRODUCTION

Date of Interview / Start and End Time.

Case Number.

Primary Interviewer Name.

Secondary Interviewer Name.

DESCRIBE THE STUDY; REMIND ABOUT CONFIDENTIALITY.

SECTION 1: ROLE AND EXPERIENCE

Q1.1 What is your present role in your organization?

Q1.2 Is this a managerial/supervisory role? Probe about knowing whom they are responding to [NOT NAMES].

Q1.3 How many years have you worked in this agency? For how long in current unit/division? For how long in current position?

Q1.4 Could you tell me a little about your path to your present job?

SECTION 2: POLICY GOALS

Q2.1 In your opinion, what are the most important policy goals of the DAO under DA Krasner's leadership? [RECORD UP TO 3].

Q2.2 What have been the primary factors – within and outside the DAO – that have helped or hindered in achieving first goal?

[ASK FOR WHAT HELPED FIRST THEN WHAT HINDERS].

Q2.3 What have been the primary factors – within and outside the DAO – that have helped or hindered in achieving second goal? [ASK FOR WHAT HELPED FIRST THEN WHAT HINDERS]

Q2.4 What have been the primary factors – within and outside the DAO – that have helped or hindered in achieving this third goal? [ASK FOR WHAT HELPED FIRST THEN WHAT HINDERS].

SECTION 3: POLICY IMPACT

Q3.1 Do you think DA Krasner's policies as a whole are having any impacts - positive and/or negative?

Q3.2 On Philadelphia's Criminal Justice System; What parts of CJ (police, courts, corrections)?

Q3.3 On Philadelphia's Communities? What parts of communities (defendants, victims, public)?

[PROMPT FOR POSITIVES THEN NEGATIVES FOR EACH AND EXPLANATIONS OF ANSWERS].

SECTION 4: IMPACT OF SPECIFIC POLICIES

Q4.1 The DAO specifically identified some specific policies as priorities or potentially having an impact on CJS and/or the community. I'm going to ask, whether you are aware of them and your views about their impact.

[ASK ONLY ABOUT THOSE NOT MENTIONED IN PREVIOUS ANSWER; PROBE FOR EXPLANATIONS OF ANSWERS AND EXAMPLES].

Q4.2 Policies targeting mass incarceration/mass supervision (e.g., plea bargaining, sentencing, violations of probation/parole): Do you feel these policies have had any impacts - positive and/or negative?

Q4.3 Bail policies (e.g. reduce cash bail, eliminate for certain offenses, COVID policy - \$999,999 cash).

Q4.4 Charging policies in lower-level cases (non-cannabis) (e.g. prostitution, retail theft, possession of buprenorphine or fentanyl test strips).

Q4.5 Gun/shooting/homicide case policies (e.g., combining homicide and non-fatal shootings unit, VUFA case processing, intelligence unit).

Q4.6 Cannabis policies (e.g., possession, dealing, DUI).

Q4.7 Diversion policies (e.g., accelerated misdemeanor expansion; prostitution, 1st DUI).

Q4.8 Immigration policies (e.g., consider disproportionate consequences, refer to immigration counsel).

Q4.9 Juvenile policies (e.g., deferred adjudication, decrease incarceration, limit transfer to adult court).

Q4.10 Victim related policies (e.g., improve timeliness of communication, consider victim input etc.)

Q4.11 If you were to try to locate a specific policy for reference, would you know where/how to access it?

SECTION 5: INTERACTIONS WITH OTHER AGENCIES

Q5.1 How would you describe – from your perspective - the overall nature of the relationship between the DAO under DA Krasner and other criminal justice agencies?

Q5.2 Are there any particular agencies with which the DAO under DA Krasner has faced difficult challenges around changes to any DAO policy and practice? [RECORD UP TO 3 AGENCIES].

Q5.3 Agency #1: [ASK FOR AGENCY #1] What is the nature of the challenge between Agency 1 and the DAO?

Q5.4 Agency #2: [ASK FOR AGENCY #2] What is the nature of the challenge between Agency 2 and the DAO?

Q5.5 Agency #3: [ASK FOR AGENCY #3] What is the nature of the challenge between Agency 3 and the DAO?

SECTION 6: PPM GUIDELINES-SPECIFIC. The current administration is often referred to as “progressive”.

Q6.1 In your view what makes a prosecutorial/DAO

progressive? What would be the successful elements of a progressive prosecutorial office?

[USE PPM GUIDELINES LIST BELOW AS PROBES AFTER RECORDING INITIAL ANSWER].

Published work on PPM suggests a number of recommendations or guidelines for progressive chief prosecutors wishing to implement change. As I mention some of these (organized into a few categories) please indicate any you feel have had an impact - either positive or negative - on DA Krasner's efforts to implement change in Philadelphia?

[FOR EACH GUIDELINE ASK HOW MUCH IT OCCURRED AND WHAT IMPACT, WITH EXAMPLES, POSITIVE OR NEGATIVE, ON THE DAO'S ABILITY TO IMPLEMENT CHANGE AND THEIR OWN WORK EXPERIENCE].

Q6.2 The first category is COMMUNICATION:

Q6.2.1 Communicate early and often with others in the local criminal justice system about policy changes.

Q6.2.2 Seek input, listen, and respond to concerns of others in the local criminal justice system about proposed policy changes.

Q6.2.3 Engage the community by seeking input, listening, and responding to their concerns and/or by encouraging prosecutors to engage in community outreach.

Q6.3 The second category is EDUCATION AND TRAINING:

Q6.3.1 Provide DAO staff with education and training covering major policies targeted by policies e.g. mass incarceration, racial disparity in the criminal justice system, criminalization of poverty etc.

Q6.3.2 Set up programs and opportunities for prosecutors to visit prisons and jails where the people they prosecute are held; meet with formerly incarcerated individuals and their families; meet with people who have been exonerated.

Q6.4 The third category is LEADERSHIP AND HIRING/STAFFING POLICIES:

Q6.4.1 Replace existing prosecutors who are not receptive to change and hire only those prosecutors who are receptive to change.

Q6.4.2 Hire a diverse staff across all levels and report out on staff diversity.

Q6.5 The fourth category is TRANSPARENCY AND ACCOUNTABILITY:

Q6.5.1 Adopt performance standards/measures that reflect progressive values (e.g., metrics on reducing incarceration, pretrial detention).

Q6.5.2 Make data available to the public to improve accountability.

Q6.5.3 Set procedures for defendants/defense attorneys to appeal prosecutorial decisions perceived as unfair (such as charging, or plea offers) to a supervising prosecutor.

Q6.6 Do you see evidence that the current DAO leadership is learning from prior mistakes/failures? [PROMPT FOR ANY YES/NO EXAMPLES].

SECTION 7: COVID IMPACT

Q7.1 Thinking about what we have discussed, to what extent would you say that your **observations, beliefs and opinions** about what you shared in this interview have remained the same or changed from pre-COVID to today.

Q7.2 In what ways are they different? [PROMPT FOR EXAMPLE OF WHERE DIFFERENT].

CLOSING STATEMENT - EXTEND THANKS

Data availability

Due to the sensitive and confidential nature of the qualitative data used in this project and to abide by the IRB Protocol governing the protection of the human subjects involved in the project, the data used in this project is unavailable for sharing.

References

- Agan, A., Doleac, J. L., & Harvey, A. (2021). *Prosecutorial reform and local crime rates*. Law & Economics Center at George Mason University Scalia Law School Research Paper Series (22-011).
- Ahlin, E. M. (2019). *Semi-structured interviews with expert practitioners: Their validity and significant contribution to translational research*.
- Amaral, F. A., Loeffler, C. E., & Ridgeway, G. (2024). Prosecutorial discretion not to invoke the criminal process and its impact on firearm cases. *Journal of Criminal Justice*, 95, 102313.
- Austen, B. (2018, Oct 30). In Philadelphia, a progressive D.A. tests the power — And learns the limits — Of his office: Feature. *New York Times (Online)*. <https://www.nytimes.com/2018/10/30/magazine/larry-krasner-philadelphia-district-attorney-prgressive.html>.
- Balboni, J. M., & Grometstein, R. (2020). Prosecutorial reform from within: District attorney 'disruptors' and other change agents, 2016–2020. *Contemporary Justice Review*, 23(3), 261–290. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10282580.2020.1783255>
- Bazelon, Emily. (2019). *Charged: The New Movement to Transform American Prosecution and End Mass Incarceration*.
- Bidar, M. (2022, Jun 8). San Francisco votes overwhelmingly to recall progressive DA Chesa Boudin. *CBS News*. <https://www.cbsnews.com/news/chesa-boudin-san-francisco-da-recalled/>.
- Black, D. J. (1972). The boundaries of legal sociology. *The Yale Law Journal*, 81, 1086.
- Bourdieu, P. (1987). The force of law: Toward a sociology of the juridical field. *Hastings Law Journal*, 38(5), 805–853.
- Campeau, H. (2019). Institutional myths and generational boundaries: Cultural inertia in the police organisation. *Policing and Society*, 29(1), 69–84.
- Carrillo, J. D., & Gromb, D. (2007). Cultural inertia and uniformity in organizations. *The Journal of Law, Economics, & Organization*, 23(3), 743–771.
- Concannon, C., & Hemmady, S. (2020). How data analysis can shape diversion policy. *Criminal Law Practitioner*, 11(1) [i]–67.
- Cordeiro, M. (2017, April 3). Rick Scott reassigns murder cases away from State Attorney Aramis Ayala. *Orlando Weekly*. <https://perma.cc/C84J-C3LU>.
- Dahm, D. (2019, Feb 5). Former assistant to Aramis Ayala running against her for state attorney. *ClickOrlando.com*. <https://www.clickorlando.com/news/2019/02/05/former-assistant-to-aramis-ayala-running-against-her-for-state-attorney/>.
- Davis, A. J. (2019). Reimagining prosecution: A growing progressive movement. *UCLA Criminal Justice Law Review*, 3(1), 29.
- Davis, A. J. (2022). The perils of private prosecutions. *California Law Review Online*, 13, 7.
- Davis, R. C., Reich, W. A., Rempel, M., & Labriola, M. (2021). A multisite evaluation of prosecutor-led pretrial diversion: Effects on conviction, incarceration, and recidivism. *Criminal Justice Policy Review*, 32(8), 890–909. <https://doi.org/10.1177/08874034211000403>
- Dover, T. L., Kaiser, C. R., & Major, B. (2020). Mixed signals: The unintended effects of diversity initiatives. *Social Issues and Policy Review*, 14(1), 152–181.
- Eisenstein, J., Flemming, R., & Peter Nardulli, P. (1988). *The contours of justice: Communities and their courts*. Boston: Little, Brown.
- Eisenstein, J., & Jacob, H. (1977). *Felony justice: An organizational analysis of criminal courts*. Boston: Little, Brown.
- Fair and Just Prosecution (FJP). (2018). 21 principles for the 21st century prosecutor. <https://perma.cc/3DRW-U8ZH>.
- Foglesong, T., Levi, R., Henry, L., Bouchot, E., & Wildeman, E. (2024). *Between violent crime and progressive prosecution in the United States*. Global Justice Lab: Munk School of Global Affairs and Public Policy. <https://munkschool.utoronto.ca/research/between-violent-crime-and-progressive-prosecution-united-states-2024-report>.
- Foglesong, T., Rosenfeld, R., Schoenfeld, H., Wood, J., Stemen, D., & Rengifo, A. (2022). *Violent crime and public prosecution*. Global Justice Lab: Munk School of Global Affairs and Public Policy. <https://munkschool.utoronto.ca/media/3097/download>.
- Formica, S., & Sfodera, F. (2022). The Great Resignation and Quiet Quitting paradigm shifts: An overview of current situation and future research directions. *Journal of Hospitality Marketing & Management*, 31(8), 899–907. <https://doi.org/10.1080/19368623.2022.2136601>
- Friese, S. (2019). *Qualitative data analysis with Atlas.ti* (3rd ed.). Sage Publications.
- Fuller, J., & Kerr, W. (2022). The great resignation didn't start with the pandemic. In *Harvard business review*. Harvard Business Publishing.
- Gershowitz, A. M. (2023). *The prosecutor vacancy crisis*. William & Mary Law School. Research Paper No. 09-480.
- Ghasabeh, M. S., Soosay, C., & Reaiche, C. (2015). The emerging role of transformational leadership. *The Journal of Developing Areas*, 49(6), 459–467.
- Gilley, A., McMillan, H. S., & Gilley, J. W. (2009). Organizational change and characteristics of leadership effectiveness. *Journal of Leadership and Organizational Studies*, 16(1), 38–47.
- Goldrosen, N. (2022). Null effects of a progressive prosecution policy on marijuana enforcement. *Journal of Criminology, Criminal Justice, Law & Society*, 23(1), 23–45. <https://doi.org/10.54555/cjls.4234.34103>
- Goldstein, R. (2024). Toplash: Progressive prosecutors under attack from above. *American Criminal Law Review*, 61, 1157–1203.
- Gould, J. B., & Barclay, S. (2012). Mind the gap: The place of gap studies in sociolegal scholarship. *Annual Review of Law and Social Science*, 8, 323–335.
- Grodensky, C. A., Crozier, W. E., Gifford, E. J., & Garrett, B. L. (2023). Understanding plea bargaining in a new progressive DA's office: How line prosecutors understand and implement progressive goals through plea decisions. *Criminal Justice and Behavior*, 50(3), 429–453. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00938548221140356>
- Guevara, M., & Solomon, E. (2009). *Implementing evidence-based policy and practice in community corrections*. Washington, DC, USA: US Department of Justice, National Institute of Corrections.

- Herndon, A. W. (2018, Aug 8). Wesley Bell, Ferguson Councilman, Unseats St. Louis County Prosecutor. *The New York Times*. <https://perma.cc/4QU8-T8CQ>.
- Hogan, T. P. (2022). De-prosecution and death: A synthetic control analysis of the impact of de-prosecution on homicides. *Criminology & Public Policy*, 21(3), 489–534. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1745-9133.12597>
- Johnson, K. C., Davis, R. C., Labriola, M., Rempel, M., & Reich, W. A. (2020). An overview of prosecutor-led diversion programs: A new incarnation of an old idea. *Justice System Journal*, 41(1), 63–78. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0098261X.2019.1707136>
- Kaplan, Naddeo, & Scott. (2022). *De-prosecution and death: A comment on the fatal flaws in Hogan*. <https://doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/Z4QB8>
- Kelly, D., & Amburgey, T. L. (1991). Organizational inertia and momentum: A dynamic model of strategic change. *Academy of Management Journal*, 34(3), 591–612.
- Kohler, J. (2023, Oct 11). *Police resistance and politics undercut the authority of prosecutors trying to reform the justice system*. ProPublica. <https://www.propublica.org/article/police-politicians-undermined-reform-prosecutors-chicago-philadelphia>.
- Krinsky, M. A., Murray, J., & Romero, M. (2023). Preface: New directions in prosecutorial reform. *American Criminal Law Review*, 60(4), 1369–1380.
- Kutateladze, et al. (n.d.). Prosecutorial Performance Indicators. <https://prosecutori.alperformanceindicators.org/#indicators>.
- Kutateladze, B. L., Meldrum, R., Richardson, R., Stemen, D., Webster, E., Arndt, M., ... Soor, S. (2018). *Prosecutorial attitudes, perspectives, and priorities: Insights from the inside*. MacArthur Foundation.
- Lacy, A., & Grim, R. (2019, July 8). Pennsylvania Lawmakers move to strip reformist Prosecutor Larry Krasner of authority. *The Intercept*. <https://theintercept.com/2019/07/08/da-larry-krasner-pennsylvania-attorney-general/>.
- Lattimore, P. K. (2022). Reflections on Criminal Justice Reform: Challenges and Opportunities. *Am J Crim Justice*, 47(6), 1071–1098. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12103-022-09713-5>. Epub 2022 Dec 17. PMID: 36571088; PMCID: PMC9758469.
- Levin, B. (2021). Imagining the progressive prosecutor. *Minnesota Law Review*, 105(3), 1415–1451.
- Liao, S. H., Fei, W. C., & Liu, C. T. (2008). Relationships between knowledge inertia, organizational learning and organization innovation. *Technovation*, 28(4), 183–195.
- Lin, A. C. (2002). *Reform in the making*. Princeton University Press.
- Lowrey-Kinberg, B., Gould, J., & Bowman, R. (2022). “Heart and soul of a prosecutor”: The impact of prosecutor role orientation on charging decisions. *Criminal Justice and Behavior*, 49(2), 239–258. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00938548211041645>
- MacDonald, J., Mohler, G., & Jeffrey Brantingham, J. P. (2022). 165 (Part A). *Association between race, shooting hot spots, and the surge in gun violence during the COVID-19 pandemic in Philadelphia* (p. 107241). New York and Los Angeles: Preventive Medicine. ISSN 0091-7435 <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ypmed.2022.107241>.
- Matei, A., Robin, L., Freeman, K. R., & Courtney, L. (2022). *An exploration of prosecutorial discretion in plea bargaining in Philadelphia*. Washington, DC: Urban Institute. <https://www.urban.org/sites/default/files/202212/An%20Exploration%20of>.
- McLean, K., Cherry, T., & Alpert, G. P. (2023). Recruiting for change: Shifting focus to address a workforce crisis. *Police Practice and Research*, 24(4), 446–460. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15614263.2022.21283>
- Meldrum, R. C., Stemen, D., & Kutateladze, B. L. (2021). Progressive and traditional orientations to prosecution: An empirical assessment in four prosecutorial offices. *Criminal Justice and Behavior*, 48(3), 354–372. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0093854820956672>
- Miller, J. M., & Blumstein, A. (2020). Crime, Justice & the COVID-19 Pandemic: Toward a National Research Agenda. *Am J Crim Just*, 45, 515–524. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12103-020-09555-z>
- Mitchell, O., Mora, D. O., Sticco, T. L., & Boggess, L. N. (2022). Are progressive chief prosecutors effective in reducing prison use and cumulative racial/ethnic disadvantage? Evidence from Florida. *Criminology & Public Policy*, 21(3), 535–565. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1745-9133.12598>
- Mitchell, O., & Petersen, N. (2024). The rise of progressive prosecutors in the United States: Politics, prospects, and perils. *Annual Review of Criminology*. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-criminol-111523-122427>
- Moy, K. K., Martin, D. M., & Sklansky, D. A. (2018). *Rate my district Attorney: Toward a scorecard for prosecutors’ offices*. 29.
- Myers, V. L., & Dreachslin, J. L. (2007). Recruitment and retention of a diverse workforce: Challenges and opportunities. *Journal of Healthcare Management*, 52(5), 290–298.
- National Research Council. (2014). *The growth of incarceration in the United States: Exploring causes and consequences*. The National Academies Press. <https://doi.org/10.17226/18613>
- Ouss, A., & Stevenson, M. (2023). Does cash bail deter misconduct? *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, 15(3), 150–182.
- Owusu, F. (2022). *Presumptive declination and diversion in Suffolk County, MA*. Rappaport Institute for Greater Boston. <https://www.hks.harvard.edu/sites/default/files/Tau%20bman/RIGB/Presumptive%20Declination%20and%20Diversion%20in%20Suffolk%20County%2C%20MA.pdf>.
- Passon, T., Brook, Y., & Salazar, N. (2021). *Philly D.A.* [Film]. PBS.
- Petersen, N., Mitchell, O., & Yan, S. (2024). Do progressive prosecutors increase crime? A quasi-experimental analysis of crime rates in the 100 largest counties, 2000–2020. *Criminology & Public Policy*, 23(2), 459–490.
- Pfaff, J. F. (2017). *Locked in: The true causes of mass incarceration—And how to achieve real reform*. Basic Books.
- Philadelphia District Attorney’s Office. (2021a). Ending mass supervision: Evaluating reforms in the Philadelphia District Attorney’s Office. <https://data.philadao.com/Research.html>.
- Philadelphia District Attorney’s Office. (2021b). Overturning convictions—and an era: Convictions Integrity Unit report January 2018–June 2021. <https://data.philadao.com/Research.html>.
- Philadelphia District Attorney’s Office. (2023). Racial injustice report: Disparities in Philadelphia criminal courts from 2015–2022. <https://phillyda.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/DAO-RACIAL-INJUSTICE-REPORT-2023.pdf>.
- Pound, R. (1910). Law in books and law in action. *American Law Review*, 44, 12.
- Rex, K. (2018, Sept 7). *DA Hopeful’s “Do not Prosecute” List has critics saying she’s soft on crime*. CBS Boston. <https://perma.cc/4JBH-PAEJ>.
- Richardson, R., & Kutateladze, B. L. (2021). Tempering expectations: A qualitative study of prosecutorial reform. *Journal of Research in Crime and Delinquency*, 58(1), 41–73. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0022427820940739>
- Rozin, P., & Royzman, E. B. (2001). Negativity bias, negativity dominance, and contagion. *Personality and Social Psychology Review*, 5(4), 296–320.
- Rushing, E., Palmer, C., & Orso, A. (2022, Nov 15). Pa. House committee approves articles of impeachment against Philly DA Larry Krasner. *The Philadelphia Inquirer*. <https://www.inquirer.com/news/pa-house-judiciary-committee-krasner-impeachment-20221115.html>.
- Saldana, J. (2016). Goodall’s verbal exchange coding: An overview and example. *Qualitative Inquiry*, 22(1), 36–39.
- Sklansky, D. A. (2016). The nature and function of prosecutorial power criminology. *The Journal of Criminal Law and Criminology*, 106(3), 473–520.
- Sklansky, D. A. (2017). The progressive prosecutor’s handbook. *UC Davis Law Review Online*, 50, 25–42.
- Sklansky, D. A. (2018). The problems with prosecutors. *Annual Review of Criminology*, 1, 451–469.
- Ssentongo, P., Fronterre, C., Ssentongo, A. E., et al. (2021). Gun violence incidence during the COVID-19 pandemic is higher than before the pandemic in the United States. *Sci Rep*, 11, 20654. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-021-98813-z>
- Taqi-Eddin, J. G. (2024). *Impact Analysis of the Chesa Boudin Administration*. <https://arxiv.org/abs/2405.11455>.
- Trinacria, J. (2018, March 2). Philly FOP president blasts DA Krasner in letter to police cadets. *Philly Mag*. <https://perma.cc/L4CE-ZN3S>.
- Ulmer, J. T. (2019). Criminal courts as inhabited institutions: Making sense of differences and similarity in sentencing. *Crime and Justice*, 48(1), 483–522.
- Ward, J. T., Vilci  , E. R., Brey, J., Mohler, M. E., & Dolbear, C. (2025). Progressive prosecution policies in Philadelphia: An assessment of implementation fidelity. *American Journal of Criminal Justice*. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12103-025-09792-0>
- Wu, S., & McDowall, D. (2024). Does bail reform increase crime in New York State: Evidence from interrupted time-series analyses and synthetic control methods. *Justice Quarterly*, 41(3), 371–399.
- Yin, R. K. (2009). *Case study research design and methods*. Sage Publications.
- Zhou, A., Koo, A., Kallus, N., Ropac, R., Peterson, R., Koppel, S., & Bergin, T. (2021). An empirical evaluation of the impact of New York’s bail reform on crime using synthetic controls (arXiv:2111.08664). arXiv <http://arxiv.org/abs/2111.08664>.